ECONOMIC INTELLIGENCE SERIES

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · June 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	76.9
#2	A+	Atlanta	73.5
#3	A+	Kansas City	70.9
#4	A+	Charlotte	68.8
#5	A	Nashville	67.5
#6	A	Austin	65.2
#7	A	Hartford	63.8

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Jacksonville	22.1
#49	C-	Richmond	29.6
#48	C-	Minneapolis	30.6
#47	C-	Riverside	30.8
#46	C-	Louisville	30.9
#45	C	Sacramento	34.3
#44	C	Grand Rapids	34.5

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	10 cities
B+ / B / B-	22 cities
C+ / C / C-	17 cities
D	1 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, CLF Growth, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · June 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	**Raleigh** Raleigh-Cary	A+	76.9	3.0%	+4.1%	+2.0%	+0.9%	46 days
2	**Atlanta** Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	A+	73.5	2.8%	+5.2%	+0.2%	+0.9%	50 days
3	**Kansas City** Kansas City	A+	70.9	3.3%	+8.0%	-0.0%	+0.2%	43 days
4	**Charlotte** Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A+	68.8	3.5%	+2.1%	+1.1%	+0.2%	47 days
5	**Nashville** Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A	67.5	3.0%	+5.8%	+0.3%	+0.0%	52 days
6	**Austin** Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A	65.2	3.4%	+6.8%	+0.6%	+0.5%	56 days
7	**Hartford** Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A	63.8	2.7%	+1.5%	+1.9%	+2.8%	25 days
8	**Cincinnati** Cincinnati	A	63.2	3.1%	+4.2%	+0.3%	-1.1%	36 days
9	**Pittsburgh** Pittsburgh	A-	62.7	3.5%	+6.3%	-0.4%	+1.4%	45 days
10	**Salt Lake City** Salt Lake City-Murray	A-	62.7	3.6%	+4.3%	+1.3%	-1.1%	45 days
11	**Las Vegas** Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	B+	58.8	5.1%	+5.6%	+2.0%	+0.9%	51 days
12	**Dallas** Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B+	58.6	3.8%	+2.4%	+0.5%	+0.4%	48 days
13	**Birmingham** Birmingham	B+	55.9	2.4%	-1.2%	+0.7%	-1.0%	54 days
14	**San Diego** San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	B	54.7	4.1%	+6.8%	+0.6%	-1.5%	39 days
15	**San Francisco** San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B	54.2	3.9%	+6.7%	+0.3%	-2.4%	32 days
16	**Seattle** Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B	54.1	5.1%	+7.4%	+0.1%	-1.2%	36 days
17	**Philadelphia** Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B	53.7	3.9%	-0.4%	+0.1%	+1.0%	36 days
18	**Tampa** Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B	53.6	4.7%	+6.9%	+0.1%	+0.0%	67 days
19	**Los Angeles** Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B	53.3	4.8%	+4.8%	+1.8%	-1.6%	47 days
20	**New York** New York Newark-Jersey City	B	53.0	4.2%	+5.7%	+0.4%	-0.1%	42 days
21	**San Jose** San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	B	52.8	3.7%	0.0%	+1.3%	-1.2%	29 days
22	**Houston** Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B	52.3	4.3%	+1.9%	+0.2%	-0.1%	49 days
23	**Orlando** Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	B	50.8	4.5%	+2.8%	+1.1%	+1.1%	70 days
24	**Columbus** Columbus	B-	49.5	2.8%	+3.3%	+0.2%	-1.4%	33 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	**Cleveland** Cleveland	B-	49.0	3.4%	-0.6%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
26	**Memphis** Memphis	B-	48.9	4.1%	+6.2%	-0.1%	-0.9%	58 days
27	**St. Louis** St. Louis	B-	48.3	3.6%	+1.8%	-0.5%	+0.0%	42 days
28	**Denver** Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B-	46.8	3.5%	+0.7%	-0.2%	-2.2%	43 days
29	**Miami** Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B-	46.4	3.9%	+7.3%	-0.2%	+0.3%	79 days
30	**Virginia Beach** Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	B-	46.1	3.5%	+6.8%	-0.7%	-1.1%	33 days
31	**Fresno** Fresno	B-	46.1	8.1%	+4.2%	+1.7%	-0.2%	52 days
32	**Phoenix** Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	B-	45.5	3.8%	+3.3%	+0.6%	-2.5%	60 days
33	**Providence** Providence-Warwick	C+	43.6	4.3%	+3.5%	+0.6%	+1.7%	30 days
34	**Chicago** Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C+	41.3	4.9%	+4.3%	+0.1%	-2.6%	33 days
35	**Indianapolis** Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C+	41.2	2.6%	+0.5%	-0.7%	-0.8%	42 days
36	**San Antonio** San Antonio-New Braunfels	C+	39.7	3.8%	+1.6%	+0.0%	+0.1%	57 days
37	**Baltimore** Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	C+	39.2	4.3%	+4.9%	-0.7%	+0.0%	33 days
38	**Oklahoma City** Oklahoma City	C	37.2	3.6%	+6.2%	-1.0%	-3.0%	49 days
39	**Boston** Boston-Cambridge-Newton	C	36.6	3.9%	+3.7%	-0.4%	+2.9%	25 days
40	**Milwaukee** Milwaukee-Waukesha	C	36.3	3.7%	+1.5%	-0.9%	-0.6%	32 days
41	**Washington DC** Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	C	35.9	3.9%	+4.8%	-2.9%	-2.5%	30 days
42	**Detroit** Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C	35.6	4.4%	+2.3%	-0.9%	-0.1%	38 days
43	**Portland** Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C	35.3	4.8%	+6.2%	-2.9%	-1.6%	47 days
44	**Grand Rapids** Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	C	34.5	3.6%	+3.0%	-0.1%	-7.0%	30 days
45	**Sacramento** Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C	34.3	4.5%	+1.1%	+0.4%	-1.7%	41 days
46	**Louisville** Louisville-Jefferson County	C-	30.9	4.0%	+2.3%	-0.8%	-1.4%	38 days
47	**Riverside** Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C-	30.8	4.9%	+5.4%	+0.0%	-2.2%	56 days
48	**Minneapolis** Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C-	30.6	3.8%	+0.5%	-0.4%	-0.9%	34 days
49	**Richmond** Richmond	C-	29.6	3.4%	+3.0%	-0.5%	-0.9%	36 days
50	**Jacksonville** Jacksonville	D	22.1	4.8%	+1.2%	-0.4%	-0.5%	59 days

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #1 OF 50

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A+

EXCELLENT

76.9th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	98
Unemployment	20% weight	80
Wage Growth	15% weight	50
Cost of Living	12% weight	80
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	82
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	58
Days on Market	5% weight	48
Office Economy	3% weight	98

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+2.0%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+5.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	46 days	median, +2.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 76.9th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score in the 98th percentile, driven by a 2.02% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.762% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. The combination of strong employment growth and above-trend hours signals genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area is experiencing a significant expansion in labor demand, with a 2.02% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.762% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs at a rapid pace and workers are putting in more hours than usual. The labor demand composite score of 8.63 ranks in the 98th percentile, underscoring the city's strong job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary is 3.00%, ranking in the 80th percentile, which indicates a relatively tight labor market. With such a low unemployment rate, businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and wage pressure may be higher. This tight market implies that companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Raleigh-Cary is 4.09%, ranking in the 50th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing. While wage growth is not exceptionally high, it is still positive, providing a stable environment for businesses to operate.

Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living score ranking in the 80th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $220/sqft to $38.03/hr, or 5.78. The fact that the PSF is decreasing by 1.4% year-over-year makes the city more affordable relative to its peers. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary is growing at a rate of 0.90% year-over-year, ranking in the 82nd percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing businesses with a larger pool of potential employees to hire from. As the labor force grows, companies may find it easier to fill open positions and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Raleigh-Cary has increased by 5.85% year-over-year, ranking in the 58th percentile. This moderate growth in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. As the housing supply grows, the city may become more attractive to relocating workers and businesses.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is 46 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.2%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking in the 48th percentile, indicates a competitive market. For workers relocating to the city, this may mean that they need to act quickly to secure housing, but the market is still accessible.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 98th percentile. This makes the city an ideal location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require specialized knowledge-economy talent. However, the city may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, moderate wage growth, and an affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the tight labor market and relatively low unemployment rate may pose a challenge for businesses trying to hire, and decision-makers should factor in the potential need for competitive salaries to attract top talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #2 OF 50

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

A+

EXCELLENT

73.5th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	72
Unemployment	20% weight	88
Wage Growth	15% weight	66
Cost of Living	12% weight	67
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	80
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	64
Days on Market	5% weight	64
Office Economy	3% weight	78

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	2.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+10.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	50 days	median, +6.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 73.5th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 5.82, and its low unemployment rate of 2.80%, which signals a tight labor market. These metrics, combined with a labor force growth rate of 0.86%, indicate a city with a robust and expanding workforce.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.21% and weekly hours deviation of 1.222% above trend suggest genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a genuine increase in labor demand, rather than just a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 5.82, ranking in the 72nd percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 2.80% is exceptionally low, ranking in the 88th percentile, which indicates a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have strong bargaining power, which could drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 5.22% is above average, ranking in the 66th percentile, which indicates moderate to fast wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but workers are also experiencing an increase in purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but can also benefit from a workforce with increased disposable income.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 5.36, based on $199/sqft and $37.13/hr, and a percentile rank of 67th, the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. This affordability, combined with a modest year-over-year increase in PSF of 0.5%, makes the city an attractive location for talent, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.86% year-over-year, ranking in the 80th percentile, which indicates an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that businesses have a increasing pool of potential workers to draw from, making it easier to hire and staff operations. The growing labor force also provides a foundation for long-term economic growth and development.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is 10.47%, ranking in the 64th percentile, which indicates an expansion of housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in developer confidence, which should lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. As a result, businesses can expect a more stable and predictable housing market for their employees.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 50 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.4%, ranking in the 64th percentile. This suggests a moderate pace of home sales, which is relatively accessible for relocating workers. The rising days on market also indicates a healthy normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion, which should provide stability for businesses and their employees.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share of 3.36, ranking in the 78th percentile, the city has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors, as they can tap into a highly skilled and specialized workforce. However, the city may be less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses, which require a different type of workforce.

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, low unemployment, and moderate wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for rising labor costs and increased competition for talent, which could impact businesses' ability to hire and retain workers in this tight labor market.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #3 OF 50

Kansas City

Kansas City

A+

EXCELLENT

70.9th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	40
Unemployment	20% weight	86
Wage Growth	15% weight	98
Cost of Living	12% weight	92
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	72
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	92
Days on Market	5% weight	14
Office Economy	3% weight	28

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.3%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+8.0%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.0%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	**+0.2%**	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	**+67.4%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**43 days**	median, -8.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 70.9th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptionally high wage growth rate of 7.97% year-over-year and its top-tier unemployment rate of 3.30%, which together signal a highly competitive labor market. These metrics suggest that Kansas City is an attractive location for businesses looking to tap into a skilled and productive workforce.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's employment growth rate is -0.03% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating 0.421% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.84 corresponds to a near-median 40th percentile rank.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Kansas City is 3.30%, placing it in the top tier with an 86th percentile rank. This indicates a tight labor market with limited slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new talent. As a result, companies may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain employees.

Wage Growth

Kansas City's year-over-year wage growth rate is 7.97%, ranking it in the top tier with a 98th percentile score. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor expenses when considering a location in Kansas City.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $199/sqft to $36.17/hr, Kansas City has a top-tier affordability score, ranking 92nd percentile. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The PSF has increased by 0.5% year-over-year, but the overall affordability remains high.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Kansas City is growing at a rate of 0.25% year-over-year, corresponding to an above-average 72nd percentile rank. This expansion in labor supply suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations.

Building Permits

Kansas City has seen a 67.43% year-over-year increase in building permits, placing it in the top tier with a 92nd percentile rank. This surge in permits indicates that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, businesses can expect a more stable and attractive environment for their employees.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Kansas City is 43 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 8.5%. This corresponds to a bottom-tier 14th percentile rank, indicating a highly competitive and fast-paced housing market. Relocating workers may face challenges in finding and securing housing, which could impact their decision to move to the city.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share is below average, ranking 28th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in specialized roles, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting businesses. However, the city may still be attractive for other types of businesses, such as those in logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth, low unemployment, and expanding labor supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to tap into a skilled and productive workforce. However, the city's highly competitive housing market and potential for rising labor costs are key risks that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Kansas City as a potential location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #4 OF 50

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

A+

EXCELLENT

68.8th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	88
Unemployment	20% weight	72
Wage Growth	15% weight	28
Cost of Living	12% weight	76
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	70
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	60
Days on Market	5% weight	74
Office Economy	3% weight	82

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+9.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	47 days	median, +6.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking at the 68.8th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 88th percentile, and its above-average cost of living affordability, ranked at the 76th percentile. The combination of a 1.08% employment growth rate and a 0.846% weekly hours deviation from trend suggests a genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.08% and weekly hours deviation of 0.846% indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than the 12-month trend, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.66, ranked at the 88th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 3.50%, ranking at the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market implies that workers have more bargaining power, which could lead to upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is 2.06%, which is below average, ranking at the 28th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. While this may be beneficial for employers, it also means that workers may not see significant increases in their purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has a cost of living ranked at the 76th percentile, with a PSF of $221/sqft and average hourly earnings of $37.49/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.89. The fact that PSF is decreasing by 1.8% year-over-year makes the city more affordable relative to peers. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is growing at a rate of 0.17% year-over-year, ranking at the 70th percentile. This slow but positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, albeit at a modest pace. This implies that businesses may have a slightly easier time finding qualified workers, but the slow growth rate may still pose some challenges in meeting hiring demands.

Building Permits

The city has seen a 9.08% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking at the 60th percentile. This rising trend in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. As the housing supply grows, it may become easier for workers to find affordable housing, making the city more attractive to relocating talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 47 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.8%, ranking at the 74th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to this city, this slower market may make it easier to find a home, as there is less competition and pressure to act quickly.

Office Economy

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 82. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. On the other hand, the city may be less suitable for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant, which may require a different type of workforce.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a relatively tight labor market, and an affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the moderate wage growth rate, which may lead to upward pressure on labor costs and require businesses to offer competitive wages to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #5 OF 50

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A

VERY GOOD

67.5th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	82
Unemployment	20% weight	74
Wage Growth	15% weight	74
Cost of Living	12% weight	57
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	64
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	22
Days on Market	5% weight	60
Office Economy	3% weight	88

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-18.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	52 days	median, +6.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 67.5th percentile among 50 US metros, with its labor demand and office economy being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, scoring in the 82nd and 88th percentiles, respectively. The city's strong labor demand, driven by a +0.28% employment growth rate and +1.321% weekly hours deviation, signals genuine demand expansion. With a top-tier labor demand composite score of 6.01, Nashville's economy is characterized by a strong job market.

Labor Demand

Nashville's employment growth rate of +0.28% and weekly hours deviation of +1.321% indicate a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a strong and sustainable labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.01 further reinforces this assessment, placing the city in the top tier.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 3.00% is relatively low, ranking in the 74th percentile, which means the market is tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Nashville's year-over-year wage growth rate of +5.81% is above average, ranking in the 74th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies that employer labor costs are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, while also benefiting from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 57th, Nashville is near the median in terms of affordability, with a PSF of $263/sqft and an hourly earnings rate of $35.91/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.32. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by -0.8% YoY further enhances the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Nashville is growing at a rate of +0.02% year-over-year, which is a relatively slow expansion. While the labor force is still expanding, this slow growth rate may imply some structural headwinds for hiring in the long term. However, the current labor market remains strong, with a low unemployment rate and high labor demand.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -18.82%, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This decline in permits may signal future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of a tightening housing market on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of +6.1%. This rising days on market indicates a slowing market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as it becomes more accessible. However, this trend also suggests that the housing market may be normalizing, which could have implications for future affordability and workforce attraction.

Office Economy

Nashville's professional and office worker share is ranked in the 88th percentile, indicating a deep and talented pool of knowledge-economy workers. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

In conclusion, Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin offers businesses a strong labor market, a talented pool of office workers, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation, potentially offsetting the city's many economic advantages.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #6 OF 50

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A

VERY GOOD

65.2th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	50
Unemployment	20% weight	66
Wage Growth	15% weight	86
Cost of Living	12% weight	94
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	78
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	12
Days on Market	5% weight	72
Office Economy	3% weight	92

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.5%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-22.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	56 days	median, +21.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has an overall grade of A, ranking in the 65.2th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its top-tier wage growth and cost of living. The city's economic character is most defined by its 6.75% year-over-year wage growth and a cost of living ratio of 6.38, with $240/sqft (decreasing by 8.1% YoY) compared to $37.61/hr. These metrics suggest a strong labor market with attractive affordability.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 0.63% year-over-year, combined with a -0.498% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating a near median labor demand composite score of 4.68. This combination signals a moderate expansion in genuine demand, as hours are not significantly above trend during job growth. The labor market is thus characterized by steady, albeit not spectacular, job additions.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos stands at 3.40%, placing it in the 66th percentile, which means the market has less slack than average. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with potential upward pressure on wages. However, it also suggests a skilled and engaged workforce.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.75%, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos experiences fast wage growth, ranking in the 86th percentile. This rapid increase in wages suggests rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos has a cost of living percentile rank of 94th, indicating it is more affordable than most of its peers, with a PSF to earnings ratio of 6.38 ($240/sqft vs $37.61/hr) and a decreasing PSF trend (-8.1% YoY). This affordability is a significant talent attraction advantage, as businesses can recruit without needing to offer substantial wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is growing at a rate of 0.54% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking in the 78th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -22.85%, placing Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos in the bottom tier for this metric. This significant decline in building permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos currently sit on the market for 56 days, with a year-over-year increase of 21.7%, ranking in the 72nd percentile. This indicates a slower market, which can be more accessible for relocating workers, providing them with more time to find suitable housing without facing extreme competition.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranked in the 92nd percentile, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy roles, but less ideal for those dominated by industrial or logistics sectors.

In conclusion, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos offers businesses a unique blend of strong wage growth, attractive affordability, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an excellent location for knowledge-economy businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by a sharp decline in building permits, which could erode the city's affordability advantage and hinder workforce accommodation in the future.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #7 OF 50

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A

VERY GOOD

63.8th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	90
Unemployment	20% weight	98
Wage Growth	15% weight	18
Cost of Living	12% weight	55
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	96
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	16
Days on Market	5% weight	0
Office Economy	3% weight	38

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **2.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+1.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.9%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+2.8%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-20.6%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **25 days** median, -16.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has an overall grade of A, ranking in the 63.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its top-tier labor demand and extremely low unemployment rate of 2.70%. The city's economic character is defined by its strong employment growth and tight labor market, with a labor demand composite score of 6.66, ranking in the 90th percentile. This suggests a city with genuine demand expansion, driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +1.88% year-over-year, combined with a -0.272% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in slightly fewer hours, suggesting a healthy and sustainable labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.66, ranking in the 90th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 2.70%, ranking in the 98th percentile, indicating an extremely tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have strong bargaining power, which could drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +1.48%, ranking in the 18th percentile, indicating relatively slow wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but workers may have limited bargaining power and purchasing power may not be increasing quickly. The slow wage growth may make it easier for businesses to manage labor costs, but could also limit the attractiveness of the city to workers.

Cost of Living

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has a cost of living score of 55th percentile, with a PSF of $254/sqft and average hourly earnings of $39.73/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.39. The city's PSF is falling by -1.6% year-over-year, making it relatively more affordable. This means that the city has a moderate cost of living, which could be attractive to workers without requiring significant wage premiums, giving businesses a talent attraction advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is growing at a rate of +2.77% year-over-year, ranking in the 96th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. This suggests that businesses will have access to a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier to hire and expand operations. The strong labor force growth also indicates a healthy and dynamic labor market.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is decreasing by -20.59% year-over-year, ranking in the 16th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This suggests that the city may face future affordability challenges and limitations in accommodating a growing workforce, which could impact businesses' ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 25 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -16.7%, ranking in the 0th percentile. This indicates a highly competitive and fast-paced housing market, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The low days on market suggests that the city's housing market is highly sought after, but may be difficult for workers to navigate.

Office Economy

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has an office economy score ranking in the 38th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep pool of specialized office workers, such as tech or finance companies, but may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with low unemployment and growing workforce supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand. However, the city's slow wage growth and tightening housing supply may pose challenges for businesses looking to attract and retain talent, and the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for future affordability challenges and limitations in accommodating a growing workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #8 OF 50

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

A

VERY GOOD

63.2th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	46
Unemployment	20% weight	94
Wage Growth	15% weight	54
Cost of Living	12% weight	71
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	32
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	72
Days on Market	5% weight	92
Office Economy	3% weight	40

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+16.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	36 days	median, +9.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A, ranking in the 63.2th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low unemployment rate of 3.10% and a strong building permits growth of +16.86% YoY. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, indicating a tight labor market and an expanding housing supply. With a labor demand composite score of 4.60, Cincinnati's economy is showing signs of stability.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate is +0.30% YoY, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.124% from its own trend, signaling a near median labor demand. This combination indicates a moderate expansion of jobs, but with hours worked slightly below trend, suggesting some degree of stability rather than rapid growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.60 reinforces this assessment, placing the city near the median in terms of job market vitality.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.10%, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This low unemployment rate means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is small, leading to potential wage pressure. Companies looking to staff up in Cincinnati should be prepared to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cincinnati is +4.25% YoY, placing it near the median in terms of hourly earnings increase. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace, while workers benefit from increased purchasing power. The wage growth rate is neither excessively high nor stagnant, providing a relatively stable environment for businesses to plan their labor costs.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati's cost of living, with a PSF of $195/sqft and an average hourly earnings of $35.36, results in a ratio that places it in the 71st percentile in terms of affordability. This means the city is more affordable than many of its peers, which can be a significant talent attraction advantage without needing to offer wage premiums. The affordability of Cincinnati makes it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand without incurring high labor costs due to the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is growing at a rate of -1.12% YoY, indicating a contraction in the labor pool. This negative growth rate suggests that the supply of workers is shrinking, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion in the city.

Businesses should factor in the potential challenges of finding and retaining talent in a shrinking labor market.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Cincinnati has increased by +16.86% YoY, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This growth in residential construction permits is a positive indicator for future affordability and the ability to accommodate a growing workforce. As housing supply expands, Cincinnati is likely to remain an attractive location for workers and businesses alike, with improving affordability and reduced pressure on housing prices.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Cincinnati is 36 days, with a YoY increase of +9.1%, placing it in the top tier for slower market conditions. This indicates a more accessible and less competitive market for workers relocating to the city, as homes are taking longer to sell. The rising days on market, despite a strong job market, suggests a healthy normalization in the housing market, making it easier for newcomers to find and purchase homes.

Office Economy

Cincinnati's professional and office worker share is ranked in the 40th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of talent pool in these sectors. The city is suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy, but it may not offer the same level of specialized talent as cities with a deeper knowledge-economy base. While Cincinnati can support a variety of business types, it might be less ideal for tech, finance, or consulting firms that require a highly specialized workforce.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and an expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for those who can navigate its competitive hiring environment. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which could impact the city's ability to support long-term business growth and expansion.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #9 OF 50

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

A-

GOOD

62.7th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	34
Unemployment	20% weight	78
Wage Growth	15% weight	82
Cost of Living	12% weight	82
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	90
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	46
Days on Market	5% weight	30
Office Economy	3% weight	46

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.5%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+6.3%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.4%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	**+1.4%**	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	**-3.7%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**45 days**	median, -2.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 62.7th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.34%, and its low unemployment rate of 3.50%, which ranks in the 78th percentile. These metrics suggest a competitive labor market with rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is -0.43% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.173% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate and hours worked are below trend. This scenario may lead to a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.50%, ranking in the 78th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with low slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. With a tight market, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Pittsburgh's year-over-year wage growth rate is 6.34%, ranking in the 82nd percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs. This strong wage growth benefits workers' purchasing power but may increase labor costs for employers. As a result, businesses should factor in rising labor expenses when considering Pittsburgh as a location.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh has a cost of living score ranking in the 82nd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $172/sqft to $33.65/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.11. Although the PSF is rising 1.8% year-over-year, the city's overall affordability is still relatively high compared to peers. This means that Pittsburgh has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live in the city without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of 1.38% year-over-year, ranking in the 90th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing a positive implication for hiring capacity. As the labor force grows, businesses can tap into a increasing pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

Pittsburgh's residential building permits have decreased by 3.72% year-over-year, ranking near the median. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As a result, businesses should consider the potential impact of limited housing supply on their employees' ability to find affordable housing.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Pittsburgh is 45 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.2%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, making it competitive for workers relocating to the city. However, the decreasing days on market suggests that the market is still accessible, and workers can find homes relatively quickly.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's professional and office worker share ranks near the median, with a composite score of 2.44. This suggests that the city has a moderate talent pool suited for tech, finance, and consulting businesses. While Pittsburgh is not dominated by these sectors, it still offers a deep enough knowledge-economy talent pool to support businesses in these industries.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers a competitive labor market with strong wage growth and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses. However, the city's tightening housing supply, as indicated by the decline in building permits, poses a significant risk to future affordability and workforce accommodation, and decision-makers should carefully consider this constraint when evaluating Pittsburgh as a potential location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #10 OF 50

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

A-

GOOD

62.7th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	84
Unemployment	20% weight	58
Wage Growth	15% weight	58
Cost of Living	12% weight	39
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	36
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	78
Days on Market	5% weight	50
Office Economy	3% weight	94

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.3%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+23.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	45 days	median, +2.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking in the 62.7th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 84th percentile, and its deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 94th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.33% year-over-year employment growth rate and a slight deviation in weekly hours, indicating genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has seen a 1.33% year-over-year employment growth rate, combined with a -0.047% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as hours are not significantly above trend despite job growth. The labor demand composite score of 6.12 ranks in the top tier, at the 84th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray is 3.60%, ranking in the near median 58th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced market, neither extremely tight nor slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests a manageable hiring process, without excessive wage pressure or significant staffing challenges.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Salt Lake City-Murray is 4.31%, ranking in the near median 58th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, while workers enjoy increasing purchasing power. The wage growth is neither extremely fast nor stagnant, providing a relatively stable environment for businesses.

Cost of Living

Salt Lake City-Murray has a cost of living score ranking in the 39th percentile, with a PSF of $266/sqft and average hourly earnings of $39.12/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.80. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The cost of living is not favorable for talent attraction without wage premiums, as the city's affordability is below average.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray has contracted by 1.05% year-over-year, ranking in the below average 36th percentile. This decline in labor force supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the available workforce is shrinking. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified candidates, potentially leading to increased competition for talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Salt Lake City-Murray has increased by 23.54% year-over-year, ranking in the above average 78th percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive signal for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it may help alleviate potential housing shortages and reduce costs for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Salt Lake City-Murray is currently 45 days, with a 2.3% year-over-year increase. This indicates a relatively balanced market, neither extremely competitive nor accessible. For a worker relocating to this city, the market is moderately competitive, with homes selling at a moderate pace.

Office Economy

The professional talent pool in Salt Lake City-Murray is deep, ranking in the top tier 94th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. In contrast, the city may be less suitable for industries with predominantly industrial or logistics-based workforces.

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy companies. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively expensive cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially offsetting some of the city's other advantages.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #11 OF 50

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

58.8th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	94
Unemployment	20% weight	22
Wage Growth	15% weight	70
Cost of Living	12% weight	45
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	84
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	0
Days on Market	5% weight	80
Office Economy	3% weight	86

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	5.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+2.0%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-47.4%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	51 days	median, +10.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 58.8th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 94th percentile, and its high office economy share, ranking at the 86th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 2.04% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.024% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 2.04% employment growth rate and a 0.024% increase in weekly hours above trend signals genuine demand expansion in the labor market. This indicates that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked also increasing, suggesting a strong and vibrant economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.18 further reinforces this, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 5.10%, which ranks at the 22nd percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire workers, as there is a pool of available labor. However, the relatively high unemployment rate compared to other metros may also imply weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in this metro area is 5.63%, which is above average, ranking at the 70th percentile. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power. The moderate to fast wage growth rate indicates a competitive labor market where businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 7.96, which is near the median, and a percentile rank of 45, Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is neither extremely affordable nor expensive compared to its peers. The PSF of $264/sqft is decreasing by 2.2% year-over-year, which slightly improves affordability. This means that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to cost of living alone, but it also does not require substantial wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is growing at a rate of 0.95% year-over-year, which ranks at the 84th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing businesses with a growing pool of potential employees. The positive labor force growth rate is a favorable sign for hiring capacity and future business expansion.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -47.38%, which ranks at the 0th percentile, indicating a significant tightening of housing supply. This sharp decline in building permits signals a potential future affordability crisis and workforce accommodation challenges, as the supply of new housing units is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.9%, ranking at the 80th percentile. This suggests a slower market where homes are taking longer to sell, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city as it indicates a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share composite score of 3.66, ranking at the 86th percentile, Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas has a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. This city is well-suited for knowledge-economy businesses but may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in residential building permits, which may lead to future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges, potentially offsetting the benefits of the city's otherwise favorable economic conditions.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #12 OF 50

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

58.6th percentile

Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	64
Unemployment	20% weight	46
Wage Growth	15% weight	34
Cost of Living	12% weight	84
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	76
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	44
Days on Market	5% weight	68
Office Economy	3% weight	96

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-5.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	48 days	median, +6.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 58.6th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score at the 64th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 84th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend, signaling genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has seen employment growth of 0.51% year-over-year, combined with weekly hours 0.186% above its own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 5.20 is at the 64th percentile, indicating a strong job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 3.80%, ranking at the 46th percentile. This rate indicates a near-median labor market, neither extremely tight nor overly slack. For a business trying to hire in this market, the moderate unemployment rate suggests a manageable hiring environment, without excessive wage pressure or staffing difficulties.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 2.44%, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while worker purchasing power is increasing at a moderate pace. The relatively slow wage growth may help keep labor costs in check for businesses.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $203/sqft to $37.61/hr, and a year-over-year decline of 1.9% in PSF, Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington ranks at the 84th percentile in affordability. This high ranking indicates that the city is highly affordable relative to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has grown 0.41% year-over-year, ranking at the 76th percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing a favorable hiring environment for businesses. The growing labor force suggests that the city can accommodate increasing hiring demands.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -4.95%, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The decrease in building permits is a cautionary signal for businesses relying on a readily available and affordable housing stock for their employees.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 48 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.7%. This increase, ranking at the 68th percentile, indicates a slowing market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city as it becomes more accessible. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranked at the 96th percentile, Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has a deep and specialized talent pool, making it highly suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is less suited for industries with primarily industrial or logistics-dominant economies, as its strength lies in its knowledge-based workforce.

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for various industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the decline in building permits, which may impact future affordability and workforce accommodation.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #13 OF 50

Birmingham

Birmingham

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

55.9th percentile

Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	78
Unemployment	20% weight	90
Wage Growth	15% weight	0
Cost of Living	12% weight	31
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	38
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	66
Days on Market	5% weight	52
Office Economy	3% weight	58

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	2.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-1.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+12.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	54 days	median, +5.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 55.9th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score at the 78th percentile, and its low unemployment rate, at 2.40% and ranked at the 90th percentile. These metrics signal a city with a tight labor market and genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate is +0.66% year-over-year, combined with a +0.680% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 5.90 further reinforces this interpretation, indicating a strong and growing labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Birmingham is 2.40%, ranking at the 90th percentile and indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent and may need to offer higher wages to attract workers. The low unemployment rate suggests that the market has little slack, making it challenging for companies to find and hire qualified employees.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Birmingham is -1.22% year-over-year, indicating stagnant or even declining wages. This slow wage growth will keep labor costs flat for employers, but it also means that workers will have weak bargaining power and limited purchasing power. The implication is that businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the disposable income to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Birmingham has a cost of living score at the 31st percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $161/sqft to $32.72/hr, or 4.92. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The lack of affordability may make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the high cost of living may offset the advantages of working in this city.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Birmingham is shrinking at a rate of -1.03% year-over-year. This contraction in labor supply will create a structural headwind for hiring, making it even more challenging for businesses to find and attract qualified workers. The declining labor force growth rate suggests that the city's workforce is not expanding, which may limit the pool of potential employees for businesses.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Birmingham are increasing at a rate of +12.01% year-over-year. This expansion in housing supply is a positive signal for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it suggests that the city is investing in new housing stock to meet demand. The growing supply of housing may help to mitigate some of the affordability challenges faced by workers and businesses in the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Birmingham is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.9%. This indicates a relatively balanced market, neither extremely competitive nor extremely accessible. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market, but it may still pose challenges for relocating workers who need to find housing quickly.

Office Economy

Birmingham's office economy is ranked at the 58th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.88. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool, suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and office skills. The city is likely well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors, but may not be as attractive for companies that require a large pool of industrial or logistics workers.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, but also presents challenges such as a tight labor market, stagnant wage growth, and a relatively high cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which may limit the pool of potential employees and create structural headwinds for hiring.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #14 OF 50

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

B

AVERAGE

54.7th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	70
Unemployment	20% weight	50
Wage Growth	15% weight	90
Cost of Living	12% weight	12
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	22
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	50
Days on Market	5% weight	56
Office Economy	3% weight	74

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	4.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.5%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+0.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	39 days	median, +2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 54.7th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and high wage growth, at 70th and 90th percentiles, respectively. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, with employment growth at 0.64% year-over-year and weekly hours 0.303% above trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours running above trend.

Labor Demand

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.64% year-over-year and weekly hours 0.303% above trend, indicating a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and working hours, which is a positive indicator for businesses looking to expand or relocate. The labor demand composite score of 5.50 places the city in the 70th percentile, further emphasizing the strength of the labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 4.10%, which is near the median, ranking in the 50th percentile. This rate indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither too tight nor too slack, which means that businesses may face moderate competition for talent. The practical implication for a business trying to hire in this city is that they may need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract top candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 6.85%, which is in the top tier, ranking in the 90th percentile. This rapid wage growth signals that labor costs for employers are rising quickly, but it also means that workers have strong purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but they can also expect a talented and productive workforce.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living score that places it in the 12th percentile, indicating that the city is relatively expensive, with a PSF of $604/sqft and an earnings ratio of 14.03. However, the PSF is falling by 4.0% year-over-year, which is a positive trend. Despite this, the city's high cost of living may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the cost of living is a significant consideration for workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is shrinking at a rate of -1.52% year-over-year, which is below average, ranking in the 22nd percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply means that businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to hire, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. As a result, companies may need to be more competitive in their hiring practices or consider alternative locations.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 0.17%, which is near the median, ranking in the 50th percentile. This slow growth in permits suggests that the housing supply is not expanding rapidly, which may lead to future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of a tight housing market on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.6%. This indicates a relatively balanced housing market, neither too hot nor too cold. For a worker relocating to this city, the market is moderately competitive, but still accessible, with homes selling at a moderate pace.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share of 3.28, ranking in the 74th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a highly skilled and knowledgeable workforce. However, the city may be less suitable for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and high wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies that value a talented and productive workforce. However, the city's high cost of living and shrinking labor force supply are significant risks that decision-makers should factor in, as they may impact the ability to attract and retain top talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #15 OF 50

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

B

AVERAGE

54.2th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	74
Unemployment	20% weight	64
Wage Growth	15% weight	84
Cost of Living	12% weight	16
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	10
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	52
Days on Market	5% weight	4
Office Economy	3% weight	66

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-2.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+0.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	32 days	median, -8.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 54.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and high wage growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.84, which combines a +0.34% employment growth rate and a +1.065% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, the +6.70% year-over-year wage growth rate highlights the city's competitive labor market.

Labor Demand

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an employment growth rate of +0.34% and a weekly hours deviation of +1.065% from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked above the trend line, signaling a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.84, ranking in the 74th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 3.90%, ranking in the 64th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also implies upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is +6.70%, ranking in the 84th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This rapid wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers may be rising, but it also means that workers have strong purchasing power. The high wage growth rate is a double-edged sword, benefiting workers but increasing costs for businesses.

Cost of Living

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a cost of living percentile rank of 16th, with a PSF of $664/sqft and an hourly earnings rate of $50.65, resulting in a ratio of 13.11. The city's cost of living is relatively high, making it less affordable for talent, and businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract and retain workers. The -3.5% year-over-year change in PSF, however, suggests some easing in housing costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is contracting at a rate of -2.44% year-over-year, ranking in the 10th percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified talent, and the contracting labor force may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is +0.83%, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This modest increase in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, albeit slowly, which may help improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. However, the pace of expansion is not rapid enough to significantly alleviate the city's housing constraints.

Days on Market

The median days on market in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 32 days, with a year-over-year decline of -8.6%. This rapid sales pace, ranking in the 4th percentile, indicates a highly competitive market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The fast-moving market may require businesses to provide relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 66th. The city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with high wage growth, but it also presents significant challenges, including a tight labor market, high cost of living, and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent, and the contracting labor force, which may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #16 OF 50

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

B

AVERAGE

54.1th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	60
Unemployment	20% weight	2
Wage Growth	15% weight	96
Cost of Living	12% weight	41
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	30
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	90
Days on Market	5% weight	98
Office Economy	3% weight	84

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	5.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+7.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+66.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	36 days	median, +20.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 54.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its top-tier wage growth and strong building permits expansion. The city's economic character is defined by its rapid wage growth of 7.37% year-over-year and a significant increase in building permits of 66.30% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a city with a strong, expanding economy, but also one where labor costs are rising quickly.

Labor Demand

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue area has an employment growth rate of 0.08% year-over-year and weekly hours 0.670% above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a healthy labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.08, ranking in the 60th percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 5.10%, ranking in the 2nd percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring due to the low availability of workers, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. The tight market implies that employers may need to offer competitive salaries to attract talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 7.37%, ranking in the 96th percentile, indicating very fast wage growth. This rapid increase in wages suggests that labor costs for employers are rising quickly, while workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power. The strong wage growth may lead to higher labor costs for businesses, but it also indicates a talented and in-demand workforce.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue, with a PSF of $452/sqft and average hourly earnings of $47.57/hr, results in a ratio of 9.50, ranking in the 41st percentile. This indicates that the city is near the median in terms of affordability, neither extremely expensive nor very affordable. The relatively moderate cost of living means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, but the city may not have a strong talent attraction advantage due to affordability alone.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is contracting at a rate of -1.17% year-over-year, ranking in the 30th percentile. This decline in the labor force supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. The contracting labor force may limit the city's ability to support rapid business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has increased by 66.30% year-over-year, ranking in the 90th percentile. This significant expansion in housing supply suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in developer confidence and a future improvement in affordability. The rising permits indicate that the city is taking steps to address potential housing shortages and support workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of 20.0%, ranking in the 98th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to the city, this means a more accessible and less competitive housing market, potentially making it easier to find and purchase a home.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 3.58, ranking in the 84th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers, but may be less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area offers businesses a strong, expanding economy with a talented workforce, but also presents the challenge of rapidly rising labor costs. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market and shrinking labor force, which may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth and require businesses to offer competitive salaries to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #17 OF 50

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

B

AVERAGE

53.7th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	80
Unemployment	20% weight	56
Wage Growth	15% weight	4
Cost of Living	12% weight	20
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	86
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	68
Days on Market	5% weight	58
Office Economy	3% weight	40

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-0.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+12.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	36 days	median, +2.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 53.7th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and labor force growth, which stand at the 80th and 86th percentiles, respectively. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.92, combining a +0.12% employment growth rate and a +1.451% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with its labor force growth, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.12% and weekly hours deviation of +1.451% indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in economic activity, leading to more jobs being added. The labor demand composite score of 5.92 further reinforces this notion, placing the city in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.90% indicates a near-median labor market, ranking in the 56th percentile, which suggests that there is some slack in the market but not excessively so. This rate implies that while it may not be overly difficult to hire, there is still competition for talent, and businesses may face some wage pressure. However, the market is not so tight as to make hiring significantly challenging.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of -0.37% is in the bottom tier, ranking in the 4th percentile, indicating stagnant or even slightly declining wages. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also signifies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially less purchasing power. For businesses, this could mean a flat cost environment, but it may also reflect underlying economic conditions.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $233/sqft to $32.82/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.10, and ranking in the 20th percentile, Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is less affordable than many of its peers. This lower affordability score, due to the ratio being below average and the PSF not falling YoY, suggests that the city may require wage premiums to attract talent, as the cost of living is relatively high compared to earnings.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +1.02% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as the pool of potential workers is increasing. Businesses looking to expand or relocate may find this growth beneficial for their staffing needs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +12.30%, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This increase in permits suggests that developer confidence is strong, and the future housing supply is likely to improve, which could lead to better affordability and easier accommodation for the workforce. This is a positive signal for businesses concerned about the ability of their employees to find housing.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.9%, placing it near the median in terms of market speed. This indicates a relatively balanced market that is not overly competitive or accessible. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market is neither extremely fast nor slow, suggesting a moderate level of competition for homes.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score of 2.38, ranking in the 40th percentile, Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has a moderately deep professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and other types of workers, but it may not be as ideal for those seeking a deeply specialized tech, finance, or consulting talent pool.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and growing labor force, making it an attractive location for those looking to expand or relocate. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively low affordability of the city, which may necessitate wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially increasing labor costs.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #18 OF 50

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

B

AVERAGE

53.6th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	56
Unemployment	20% weight	6
Wage Growth	15% weight	92
Cost of Living	12% weight	86
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	64
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	54
Days on Market	5% weight	20
Office Economy	3% weight	52

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.7%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+6.9%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.1%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+0.0%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+1.9%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
67 days
median, +11.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 53.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and affordable cost of living. The city's economic character is defined by its top-tier wage growth of +6.90% year-over-year and a cost of living ratio of $241/sqft to $37.36/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.45, which ranks in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This combination signals a competitive labor market with rising earnings.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is +0.12% year-over-year, combined with a +0.409% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating a near median labor demand composite score of 4.88, which suggests genuine demand expansion. This signals that the city is experiencing modest job growth with hours worked above trend, indicating that the labor market is tightening. The combination of these metrics points to a labor market where jobs are being added and workers are putting in more hours.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 4.70%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. With such a low unemployment rate, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is +6.90%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, indicating fast and rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees see their earnings increase significantly over time. However, for employers, this means a rapidly changing cost environment that may impact profitability.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living ratio of $241/sqft to $37.36/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.45, which ranks in the top tier at the 86th percentile, making it more affordable relative to peers. The fact that PSF is falling by -3.2% year-over-year versus wages is a key driver of this high affordability score. This affordability advantage is a significant talent attraction factor, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is growing at a rate of +0.02% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 64th percentile, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. This modest growth in the labor force means that hiring capacity is not significantly constrained, but it also does not offer a large pool of new workers to draw from. Businesses can expect a stable, albeit not rapidly expanding, labor pool.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is +1.87%, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile, suggesting a modest expansion in housing supply. This indicates that developer confidence is present, and future housing supply is expected to increase, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth. However, the pace of this expansion is not rapid, so significant relief in terms of affordability may not be immediate.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 67 days, with a year-over-year increase of +11.7%, ranking below average at the 20th percentile. This means the market is relatively fast, with homes selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The rising days on market, despite being still relatively low, could signal a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has an office economy percentile rank of 52nd, indicating a near median depth of professional talent pool. This suggests the city is suited for businesses that require a moderate level of specialized office roles, but it may not be as competitive for tech, finance, or consulting firms that demand a very deep knowledge-economy talent pool. The city's economy is more balanced, supporting a variety of industries.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, an affordable cost of living, and a modestly expanding labor force, making it an attractive location for companies looking to balance labor costs with talent acquisition. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market, which may lead to wage pressure and challenges in finding available workers, potentially impacting business operational costs and efficiency.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #19 OF 50

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

B

AVERAGE

53.3th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	86
Unemployment	20% weight	28
Wage Growth	15% weight	60
Cost of Living	12% weight	6
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	20
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	96
Days on Market	5% weight	62
Office Economy	3% weight	60

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	4.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.8%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.6%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+80.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	47 days	median, +4.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 53.3th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its top-tier labor demand and strong building permit growth, at 86th and 96th percentiles, respectively. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.14, combining a +1.83% employment growth rate and a -0.727% weekly hours deviation, suggests genuine demand expansion. These metrics define the city's current economic character, with a notable +79.98% year-over-year increase in building permits indicating a thriving construction sector.

Labor Demand

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has a labor demand composite score of 6.14, driven by a +1.83% employment growth rate and a -0.727% weekly hours deviation from its own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs while hours worked are slightly below trend, indicating a healthy and sustainable labor market. The top-tier percentile rank of 86th suggests a strong labor market with robust job growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is 4.80%, ranking in the 28th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The relatively high unemployment rate compared to other metros suggests that the city may not experience significant wage pressure in the near term.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is +4.84%, ranking in the 60th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This suggests that employer labor costs are rising, but at a manageable rate, while worker purchasing power is increasing. The moderate wage growth rate may attract businesses looking for a balance between labor cost control and worker satisfaction.

Cost of Living

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has a cost of living ratio of $667/sqft to $41.74/hr, with a -3.0% year-over-year change in PSF, ranking in the 6th percentile, indicating a relatively expensive city. However, the declining PSF relative to wages suggests some improvement in affordability. The low percentile rank means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the high cost of living may deter some workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is shrinking at a rate of -1.55% year-over-year, ranking in the 20th percentile, indicating a contracting labor pool. This suggests that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the supply of workers is decreasing. The declining labor force growth rate may limit the city's ability to support rapid business expansion.

Building Permits

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has seen a +79.98% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking in the 96th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding housing supply. This suggests that the city is likely to experience improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for workforce growth in the future. The strong permit growth signals a positive outlook for businesses looking to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is 47 days, with a +4.4% year-over-year increase, ranking in the 62nd percentile, indicating a relatively slow market. This means that workers relocating to the city may find a more accessible and less competitive housing market, with more time to find a suitable home. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an office economy percentile rank of 60th, indicating a deep professional talent pool, suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. The city's strong office economy makes it an attractive location for businesses looking for specialized knowledge workers, but may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, moderate wage growth, and a rapidly expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to grow and attract talent. However, the city's relatively high cost of living and shrinking labor force growth rate pose significant risks and constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this location for their business.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #20 OF 50

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

B

AVERAGE

53.0th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	66
Unemployment	20% weight	42
Wage Growth	15% weight	72
Cost of Living	12% weight	10
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	54
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	86
Days on Market	5% weight	16
Office Economy	3% weight	44

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.2%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.7%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.4%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.1%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+45.3%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **42 days** median, -6.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 53.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and strong wage growth, at 66th and 72nd percentiles, respectively. The city's labor market is characterized by a 0.39% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.456% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. These metrics suggest a city with a strong foundation for business growth.

Labor Demand

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has a labor demand composite score of 5.30, driven by a 0.39% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.456% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a positive indicator for businesses looking to expand. The above-average labor demand score of 66th percentile further reinforces this trend.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 4.20%, ranking in the 42nd percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively moderate unemployment rate also means that businesses may not face extreme pressure to offer high wages to attract talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 5.68%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating strong and above-average wage growth. This rapid wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers may be rising, but it also means that workers have increased purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses relying on local consumer demand. The strong wage growth is a double-edged sword, offering both opportunities and challenges for businesses.

Cost of Living

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has a cost of living score in the 10th percentile, with a price-to-square-foot ratio of $532/sqft and average hourly earnings of $41.11/hr, resulting in a ratio of 12.94. This low percentile rank indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The slight decline in PSF of -0.2% year-over-year offers some relief but is not enough to significantly impact the overall affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has a year-over-year growth rate of -0.14%, ranking in the 54th percentile, indicating a near-median but slightly contracting labor force. This contraction suggests that the supply of potential workers is not expanding, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion in the long term. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development programs.

Building Permits

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has seen a 45.32% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking in the 86th percentile, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This surge in building permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and the future housing supply is likely to increase, which could improve affordability and make the city more attractive to relocating workers. This trend is positive for businesses concerned about the ability of their employees to find affordable housing.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 42 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -6.7%, ranking in the 16th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market where homes sell quickly, which can be challenging for relocating workers. The fast market suggests that workers may face competition when looking for housing, potentially affecting their decision to relocate to the area.

Office Economy

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an office economy score ranking in the 44th percentile, with a share of jobs in professional and office sectors indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and other types of workers but may not be the best fit for those requiring an extremely deep knowledge-economy talent pool. The city's economy is more balanced, supporting a variety of business types.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and strong wage growth, indicating a vibrant economy. However, the city's relatively high cost of living and contracting labor force supply pose significant risks that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this location for business expansion or relocation. The balance between these factors will be crucial in determining the city's attractiveness to businesses and workers alike.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #21 OF 50

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

B

AVERAGE

52.8th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	96
Unemployment	20% weight	74
Wage Growth	15% weight	6
Cost of Living	12% weight	2
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	28
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	62
Days on Market	5% weight	24
Office Economy	3% weight	90

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	0.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+9.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	29 days	median, +7.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 52.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its exceptional labor demand and deep office economy. The city's labor demand composite score of 7.35, which combines a 1.32% employment growth rate and a 1.205% weekly hours deviation above trend, signals a genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with its high share of professional and office workers, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has seen a 1.32% employment growth rate year-over-year, combined with a 1.205% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend, indicating a strong labor demand. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, where more jobs are being added and hours are increasing, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.35 places the city in the top tier, at the 96th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara stands at 3.70%, which places it in the 74th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as potential upward pressure on wages. However, it also suggests a skilled and engaged workforce.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 0.00%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This stagnant wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not increasing, but it also indicates weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. This could impact the attractiveness of the area for talent seeking better compensation.

Cost of Living

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a cost of living score that places it in the bottom tier, at the 2nd percentile, with a PSF of $844/sqft and average hourly earnings of $54.13, resulting in a ratio of 15.59. Although the PSF is decreasing by 3.0% year-over-year, the city remains relatively expensive compared to its peers. This expense could necessitate wage premiums to attract and retain talent, as the high cost of living may offset other benefits of locating in the area.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has contracted by 1.19% year-over-year, placing it in the 28th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may find it challenging to fill positions due to a shrinking pool of potential employees. This trend could exacerbate the challenges of a tight labor market.

Building Permits

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has seen a 9.92% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking it in the 62nd percentile. This increase suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. However, the current cost of living and labor market conditions may still pose challenges for attracting and retaining workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 29 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.4%, placing it in the 24th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The rising days on market, despite being still relatively low, may signal a slight normalization in the housing market.

Office Economy

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a deep professional and office worker talent pool, with a composite score ranking it in the 90th percentile. This makes the city highly suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on a knowledgeable and skilled workforce. However, it may be less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented needs.

In conclusion, the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers a unique combination of strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain types of businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the high cost of living, which could necessitate significant wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially offsetting the benefits of the area's strong economic character.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #22 OF 50

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

B

AVERAGE

52.3th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	62
Unemployment	20% weight	30
Wage Growth	15% weight	26
Cost of Living	12% weight	96
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	58
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	28
Days on Market	5% weight	88
Office Economy	3% weight	80

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	4.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.9%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-17.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	49 days	median, +11.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 52.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and highly affordable cost of living. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.18, combining a +0.22% employment growth rate and a +0.569% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, suggests genuine demand expansion. Additionally, its cost of living, with a PSF of $173/sqft and a ratio of 4.69 to hourly earnings of $36.90, ranks in the 96th percentile for affordability.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.22% and weekly hours deviation of +0.569% indicate a genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of growth, with employers adding jobs and workers putting in more hours. The labor demand composite score of 5.18, ranking in the 62nd percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.30% is below average, ranking in the 30th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer unemployed workers available to fill positions. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +1.85% is below average, ranking in the 26th percentile, suggesting moderate wage growth. This rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. While this may help keep costs under control, it also means that workers may not see significant increases in their purchasing power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 4.69 and a PSF of $173/sqft that is falling by -2.3% year-over-year relative to hourly earnings of $36.90, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands ranks in the 96th percentile for affordability. This high ranking means that the city is highly attractive for talent, as workers can afford a high quality of life without requiring significant wage premiums. The falling PSF is a key driver of this affordability, making the city an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of -0.05% year-over-year, ranking near the median in the 58th percentile, indicating a slightly contracting labor pool. This contraction implies that the supply of workers is not expanding as quickly as in other cities, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring in the future.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -17.22%, ranking in the 28th percentile, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that the city's housing stock may not be expanding quickly enough to accommodate future workforce growth, potentially leading to affordability challenges and constraints on workforce attraction.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 49 days, with a year-over-year increase of +11.4%, ranking in the 88th percentile. This slower pace of home sales means that relocating workers may find a more accessible and less competitive housing market, with more time to find the right home. However, this trend also suggests a potential normalization of the market, rather than a sign of demand erosion.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking in the 80th percentile, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. This city is well-suited for companies that require specialized knowledge-economy workers, but may be less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant workforces.

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area offers businesses a unique combination of genuine labor demand expansion and highly affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent and relocation. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, driven by a decline in building permits, which could lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce attraction.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #23 OF 50

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

B

AVERAGE

50.8th percentile

Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	92
Unemployment	20% weight	8
Wage Growth	15% weight	36
Cost of Living	12% weight	74
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	88
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	2
Days on Market	5% weight	22
Office Economy	3% weight	64

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.5%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+2.8%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+1.1%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+1.1%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-40.8%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
70 days
median, +7.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and labor force growth, at 92nd and 88th percentiles, respectively. The city's labor market is characterized by a 1.08% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.057% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend. These metrics signal a genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours increasing above trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.08% and weekly hours deviation of 1.057% above trend indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and working hours, which is a positive indicator for businesses looking to expand or relocate. The labor demand composite score of 6.87, ranking at the 92nd percentile, further reinforces this trend.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 4.50%, ranking at the 8th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also implies upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 2.81%, ranking at the 36th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a relatively slow pace, and worker purchasing power is growing, but not rapidly. The moderate wage growth may not be sufficient to keep pace with cost of living increases.

Cost of Living

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a cost of living score ranking at the 74th percentile, with a PSF of $224/sqft, which has decreased by 3.5% year-over-year, and an average hourly earnings of $33.47/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.69. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage, as businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is growing at a rate of 1.07% year-over-year, ranking at the 88th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth in labor force supply is a positive indicator for businesses, as it suggests that there will be a larger pool of potential workers available for hiring, making it easier to find and attract talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has decreased by 40.79% year-over-year, ranking at the 2nd percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This sharp decline in building permits signals that the city's housing supply may not be able to keep pace with demand, which could lead to increased housing costs and reduced affordability, making it more challenging for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is currently 70 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.7%, ranking at the 22nd percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, which can be challenging for relocating workers, as they may face a more competitive and time-consuming process when searching for housing.

Office Economy

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has an office economy score ranking at the 64th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.98 out of 5. This indicates a relatively deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting industries, but less suited for those in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a relatively affordable cost of living, and a growing labor force supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the sharp decline in building permits, which could lead to increased housing costs and reduced affordability, making it more challenging for workers to relocate to the area.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #24 OF 50

Columbus

Columbus

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.5th percentile

Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	44
Unemployment	20% weight	96
Wage Growth	15% weight	42
Cost of Living	12% weight	63
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	24
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	14
Days on Market	5% weight	12
Office Economy	3% weight	32

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	2.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.3%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-20.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	33 days	median, -5.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B- and a 49.5th percentile ranking, presents a mixed economic picture. The city's labor demand and unemployment rate are the two metrics that most define its current economic character, with a labor demand composite score of 4.36 and an unemployment rate of 2.80%. These numbers indicate a near-median labor demand and a tight labor market.

Labor Demand

Columbus has an employment growth rate of +0.22% and a weekly hours deviation of -0.246% from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score that signals a near-median expansion. The combination of slow employment growth and slightly below-trend hours worked suggests a moderate labor market with some genuine demand expansion. However, the below-trend hours worked may indicate some degree of survivor squeeze.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Columbus is 2.80%, which corresponds to a top-tier percentile rank of 96th. This tight labor market implies that there is little slack, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward wage pressure. Companies looking to staff up in Columbus may face challenges in finding available talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Columbus is +3.26% year-over-year, placing it near the median in terms of wage growth. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while workers see a modest increase in their purchasing power. The wage growth is neither exceptionally strong nor stagnant, indicating a relatively stable labor cost environment.

Cost of Living

Columbus has a cost of living score that places it in the 63rd percentile, indicating that it is more affordable than many of its peer cities. With a PSF of $207/sqft and average hourly earnings of $34.44/hr, the ratio is 6.01, which is above average but becoming more affordable as PSF is falling by -0.5% YoY. This affordability advantage can be a talent attraction point for businesses without needing to offer significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Columbus is shrinking at a rate of -1.44% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This negative growth rate suggests that the hiring capacity for businesses may be constrained, as the pool of available workers is decreasing.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Columbus has decreased by -20.69% year-over-year, signaling a tightening of the housing supply. This sharp decline in permits may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, potentially affecting the city's attractiveness to both businesses and workers.

Days on Market

Homes in Columbus are currently selling at a median of 33 days on market, with a year-over-year decrease of -5.7%. This relatively fast market, corresponding to a bottom-tier percentile rank, indicates that relocating workers may face a competitive housing market, potentially making it tougher for them to find and secure housing quickly.

Office Economy

Columbus has a professional and office worker share that places it in the 32nd percentile, indicating a less deep talent pool compared to other cities. This suggests that Columbus is less suited for businesses requiring a high concentration of tech, finance, or consulting talent but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, Columbus offers a mixed bag for businesses, with its tight labor market and moderate wage growth being significant factors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply, which could limit hiring capacity and affect future workforce accommodation and affordability.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #25 OF 50

Cleveland

Cleveland

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.0th percentile

Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	52
Unemployment	20% weight	58
Wage Growth	15% weight	2
Cost of Living	12% weight	50
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	94
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	38
Days on Market	5% weight	54
Office Economy	3% weight	74

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-0.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-7.4%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	55 days	median, +7.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland earns an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.0th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand composite score of 4.73 and its bottom-tier wage growth of -0.55% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with labor demand neither strongly expanding nor contracting, but with significant downward pressure on wages.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate is +0.57% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.363% below the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not running above trend despite modest job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.73, ranking at the 52nd percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, ranking at the 58th percentile, indicating a near-median level of labor market slack. This rate suggests that the market is not overly tight, but still has some competition for jobs, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. However, it does not indicate extreme wage pressure.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cleveland is -0.55% year-over-year, placing it in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This stagnant wage growth environment means labor costs for employers are not rising, but it also signifies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. This could impact the attractiveness of the city for talent seeking better compensation.

Cost of Living

Cleveland's cost of living, with a PSF of $143/sqft and average hourly earnings of $33.75, results in a ratio of 4.24, ranking at the 50th percentile. This indicates the city is near the median in terms of affordability compared to its peers. The 13.5% year-over-year increase in PSF, however, suggests that affordability might be decreasing. A high cost of living percentile score would indicate more affordability, but Cleveland's score suggests it is neither particularly advantageous nor disadvantageous for talent attraction without wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of +1.80% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This significant expansion in labor force supply indicates a structural advantage for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is increasing. Businesses looking to expand or relocate may find this growth beneficial for their staffing needs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -7.43%, ranking below average at the 38th percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is not expanding as quickly as in other metros, potentially leading to future affordability issues and constraints on workforce accommodation. As the demand for housing continues, this could signal a tightening supply and upward pressure on housing costs.

Days on Market

Homes in Cleveland are currently sitting on the market for a median of 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.8%. This indicates a slowing market, where homes are taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to the city, this could mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market, allowing for more time to find suitable housing.

Office Economy

Cleveland's share of jobs in professional and office sectors, with a composite score of 3.28, ranks above average at the 74th percentile. This suggests a deep talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations. However, it may be less ideal for industries requiring a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and a deep professional talent pool, but it is also characterized by stagnant wage growth and a potentially tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker considering Cleveland is the implications of its weak wage growth on both labor costs and worker purchasing power, which could impact the city's attractiveness for both businesses and talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #26 OF 50

Memphis

Memphis

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.9th percentile

Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	14
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	76
Cost of Living	12% weight	98
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	44
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	84
Days on Market	5% weight	42
Office Economy	3% weight	6

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	4.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+39.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	58 days	median, +1.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 48.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high wage growth, with a year-over-year change of +6.18% ranking it in the 76th percentile. These metrics suggest a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities.

Labor Demand

Memphis has an employment growth rate of -0.11% and a weekly hours deviation of +1.898% from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 2.65, which ranks in the bottom tier. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, with hours above trend during job losses indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding skilled workers to fill new positions.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis is 4.10%, ranking it in the 36th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that businesses may have an easier time hiring workers, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. With an unemployment rate above the national average, Memphis may offer a more accessible labor market for companies looking to expand.

Wage Growth

Memphis has a year-over-year wage growth rate of +6.18%, ranking it in the 76th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This suggests that employer labor costs are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but may also benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Memphis has a cost of living score ranking it in the 98th percentile, with a PSF of $155/sqft and an average hourly earnings of $32.45/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.78. This means that the city is highly affordable relative to its peers, with a PSF that is falling by -6.1% year-over-year. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor for businesses, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is growing at a rate of -0.89% year-over-year, ranking it near the median. This indicates that the labor force supply is contracting, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. As a result, businesses may need to invest in workforce development programs or consider relocating workers from other areas.

Building Permits

Memphis has a year-over-year change in building permits of +39.70%, ranking it in the 84th percentile, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is likely to increase, which can improve affordability and workforce accommodation. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract and retain workers in the long term.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Memphis is 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.8%. This indicates a relatively slow market, ranking it near the median. For workers relocating to this city, this means that they may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, with more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

Memphis has an office economy score ranking it in the 6th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers of 0.58. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy workforce, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses that require a different type of workforce.

In conclusion, Memphis offers a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities for businesses. While it has a highly affordable cost of living and fast wage growth, its low labor demand and contracting labor force supply pose significant risks. The single biggest constraint for businesses considering Memphis as a location is the limited availability of skilled workers, which may require investments in workforce development or relocation programs.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #27 OF 50

St. Louis

St. Louis

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.3th percentile

Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	30
Unemployment	20% weight	70
Wage Growth	15% weight	24
Cost of Living	12% weight	59
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	60
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	56
Days on Market	5% weight	82
Office Economy	3% weight	14

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+4.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	42 days	median, +7.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 48.3th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.63 ranking it at the 30th percentile, and its above-average unemployment rate of 3.60%, which ranks it at the 70th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a relatively tight labor market but sluggish job growth.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in St. Louis is -0.48% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the city's own 12-month baseline by -0.025%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The negative employment growth rate suggests that payrolls are contracting, which may lead to a surplus of workers in certain industries.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis is 3.60%, which is relatively low and ranks the city at the 70th percentile. This tight labor market implies that there may be wage pressure and difficulty hiring, as workers have more bargaining power. For a business trying to hire in this city, it may be challenging to find and retain top talent due to the competitive job market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in St. Louis is +1.80%, which is below average and ranks the city at the 24th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in other cities. Workers in St. Louis may not have strong bargaining power, which could impact their purchasing power and overall standard of living.

Cost of Living

St. Louis has a cost of living score that ranks it at the 59th percentile, with a PSF of $166/sqft and average hourly earnings of $37.52/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.42. This indicates that the city is near the median in terms of affordability. The stable PSF growth rate of +0.0% year-over-year suggests that the city's affordability is not changing significantly. This relatively affordable cost of living could be a talent attraction advantage for businesses, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is growing at a rate of +0.01% year-over-year, which is above average and ranks the city at the 60th percentile. This slow but positive growth rate suggests that the workforce supply is expanding, albeit at a slow pace. For businesses, this implies that hiring capacity may not be severely constrained, but it may still be challenging to find skilled workers in certain industries.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in St. Louis is increasing by +4.06% year-over-year, which ranks the city at the 56th percentile. This moderate growth rate suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. However, the relatively slow pace of growth may not be enough to keep up with demand, potentially leading to future affordability challenges.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in St. Louis is 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.7%, ranking the city at the 82nd percentile. This slower market suggests that workers relocating to the city may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market. However, the rising days on market may also indicate a normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

St. Louis has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking it at the 14th percentile. This suggests that the city may not be well-suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more suitable for industries that require a more general or industrial workforce.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a slow but positive labor force growth rate, making it an attractive location for businesses that prioritize these factors. However, the city's below-average labor demand and moderate wage growth rate may pose challenges for businesses that require a skilled and growing workforce, and the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for a tight labor market to drive up wages and reduce hiring capacity.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #28 OF 50

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

46.8th percentile

Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	28
Unemployment	20% weight	80
Wage Growth	15% weight	12
Cost of Living	12% weight	53
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	12
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	80
Days on Market	5% weight	96
Office Economy	3% weight	56

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-2.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+30.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	43 days	median, +13.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 46.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the 28th percentile, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.50% ranking in the 80th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is -0.24% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.467%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze, as hours are slightly above trend despite job losses. This metric suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding the right talent to support growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 3.50%, ranking in the 80th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, potentially driving up wages and making it harder to staff open positions. As a result, companies may need to offer more competitive compensation packages to attract and retain employees.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +0.74%, ranking in the 12th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but may also not see a boost in consumer demand driven by rising incomes.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living score ranking in the 53rd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $290/sqft to $42.65/hr, or 6.80. The fact that PSF is falling by -3.3% year-over-year is a positive sign for affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage, as businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is shrinking at a rate of -2.22% year-over-year, ranking in the 12th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply means that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of available workers is declining. As a result, companies may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is increasing by +30.79% year-over-year, ranking in the 80th percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it suggests that the city is investing in infrastructure to support growing demand. As a result, businesses may see a more stable and affordable housing market for their employees in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of +13.2%, ranking in the 96th percentile. This means that the housing market is slowing down, with homes taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to this city, this could be a positive sign, as it may indicate a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a professional and office worker share ranking in the 56th percentile, with a composite score of 2.80 out of 5. This suggests that the city has a relatively deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, it may be less suitable for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a deep talent pool in professional sectors, but also presents significant challenges in terms of labor demand and labor force growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market and shrinking labor force supply, which may require businesses to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #29 OF 50

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

46.4th percentile

Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	38
Unemployment	20% weight	18
Wage Growth	15% weight	94
Cost of Living	12% weight	29
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	74
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	48
Days on Market	5% weight	28
Office Economy	3% weight	72

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+7.3%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.3%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-0.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	79 days	median, +2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 46.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 7.30% year-over-year and its low unemployment rate of 3.90%, which signals a tight labor market. The labor demand composite score of 3.78, although below average, is influenced by a combination of negative employment growth and slightly above-trend weekly hours.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is -0.25% year-over-year, and weekly hours are running 0.166% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.78 is below average, ranking 38th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.90%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with little slack, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward wage pressure. Businesses trying to hire in this market may face challenges in finding available talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 7.30%, which is exceptionally high and ranks in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also means workers have strong purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for increasing labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living score that ranks below average at the 29th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $358/sqft to $34.04/hr, or 10.52. Although the PSF is falling by 1.4% year-over-year, the city remains relatively expensive compared to its peers. This suggests that attracting talent without offering wage premiums could be challenging due to the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is growing at a rate of 0.35% year-over-year, which is above average and ranks at the 74th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire and grow in the area. The expanding labor force can help mitigate some of the hiring challenges posed by the low unemployment rate.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is -0.50%, which is near the median and ranks at the 48th percentile. This slight decline in building permits suggests that housing supply might not be expanding as quickly as demand, potentially leading to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 79 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.6%. This indicates a slightly slower market, ranking below average at the 28th percentile. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market is somewhat more accessible than in faster-moving markets, but the trend towards slower sales could signal a normalization rather than a buyer's market.

Office Economy

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking above average at the 72nd percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions that require a knowledgeable and specialized workforce. However, it may be less ideal for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and a tight labor market, which can be both a benefit and a challenge. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the potential for significant wage pressure and hiring difficulties due to the low unemployment rate, which could offset some of the benefits of locating in this city. Despite this, the expanding labor force and deep professional talent pool make it an attractive location for certain types of businesses.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #30 OF 50

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

46.1th percentile

Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	4
Unemployment	20% weight	54
Wage Growth	15% weight	88
Cost of Living	12% weight	61
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	34
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	94
Days on Market	5% weight	8
Office Economy	3% weight	20

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+69.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	33 days	median, -8.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 46.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.78%, and its weak labor demand, as evidenced by a -0.73% employment growth rate and a labor demand composite score in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is -0.73% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +2.049%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion, as the increase in hours worked is likely due to a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding new talent.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 3.50%, which is near the median at the 54th percentile. This indicates that the labor market has some slack, rather than being extremely tight. For a business trying to hire, this means that there may be a slightly easier time finding candidates, but it also implies that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the relatively higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in this metro area is 6.78%, which is in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies that employer labor costs are rising, but it also means that workers have stronger purchasing power. This could be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer spending, but it may also increase costs for employers.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in this metro area is above average, with a ratio of $224/sqft to $35.44/hr, resulting in a percentile rank of 61. This means that the city is not extremely affordable, but it is also not the most expensive. The fact that PSF is increasing by 1.8% year-over-year relative to wages suggests that affordability may be decreasing over time. This could make it more challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is shrinking at a rate of -1.08% year-over-year, which is below average at the 34th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to hire, as the pool of available workers is decreasing.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in this metro area is increasing by 69.04% year-over-year, which is in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This rapid expansion in housing supply suggests that future affordability may improve, and workforce accommodation may become easier. This could be beneficial for businesses that rely on a growing and diverse workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in this metro area is 33 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 8.3%. This fast-paced market, ranked at the 8th percentile, means that homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. This may require businesses to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in this metro area is below average, ranking at the 20th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these areas, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy workforce, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and a relatively slack labor market, but it also poses challenges such as a shrinking labor force and a competitive housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the limited supply of professional and office workers, which may require businesses to adapt their hiring strategies or offer competitive incentives to attract the right talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #31 OF 50

Fresno

Fresno

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

46.1th percentile

Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	76
Unemployment	20% weight	0
Wage Growth	15% weight	52
Cost of Living	12% weight	47
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	52
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	42
Days on Market	5% weight	70
Office Economy	3% weight	26

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
8.1%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+4.2%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+1.7%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-0.2%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-6.9%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
52 days
median, +10.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Fresno has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 46.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its high labor demand composite score, which is at the 76th percentile, and its high unemployment rate of 8.10%, ranking it at the 0th percentile. These two metrics suggest a complex labor market with both strong job growth and significant slack.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is 1.67% year-over-year, and its weekly hours are deviating from trend by -0.768%, indicating genuine demand expansion. The combination of these two metrics signals that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked being slightly below trend, suggesting that the growth is not solely due to existing workers taking on more hours.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 8.10%, which is the lowest percentile rank, indicating a significant amount of slack in the labor market. This means that the market is not tight, and businesses may find it easier to hire workers without facing significant wage pressure. However, the high unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Fresno is 4.17%, which is near the median, ranking it at the 52nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not dramatically.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living score that ranks it at the 47th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $261/sqft to $33.53/hr, or 7.78. The city's PSF is falling by 0.8% year-over-year, making it relatively more affordable. This means that Fresno has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live in the city without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno is growing at a rate of -0.20% year-over-year, indicating a slight contraction in the labor pool. This suggests that the supply of workers is not expanding, which may create a structural headwind for hiring in the future.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Fresno is decreasing by 6.89% year-over-year, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Fresno is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.6%, ranking it at the 70th percentile. This means that the market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a home.

Office Economy

Fresno's professional and office worker share is ranked at the 26th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This means that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

In conclusion, Fresno offers businesses a complex labor market with both strong job growth and significant slack, as well as a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering locating in Fresno is the potential for a tightening housing supply, which may impact future affordability and workforce accommodation.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #32 OF 50

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

45.5th percentile

Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	68
Unemployment	20% weight	44
Wage Growth	15% weight	42
Cost of Living	12% weight	49
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	6
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	30
Days on Market	5% weight	38
Office Economy	3% weight	68

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.3%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-2.5%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-16.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	60 days	median, +3.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score ranking at the 68th percentile, and its labor force growth, which is contracting at a rate of -2.53% year-over-year. The labor demand is driven by employment growth of 0.62% and weekly hours deviation of 0.193% above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.62% and weekly hours deviation of 0.193% above its own trend signal genuine demand expansion in the Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area. This combination indicates that jobs are being added and hours are running above trend, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.36 further reinforces this, ranking at the 68th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 3.80%, ranking at the 44th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, this also implies that local consumer demand may not be as strong as in areas with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 3.26%, ranking at the 42nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, and worker purchasing power is increasing. The moderate wage growth may attract businesses looking for a balance between labor cost management and worker satisfaction.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 7.20, based on $271/sqft (which is falling at a rate of -1.8% year-over-year) versus $37.62/hr, Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler ranks at the 49th percentile in terms of affordability. This means the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums. The falling PSF value is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is contracting at a rate of -2.53% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding and recruiting talent in this environment.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -16.51%, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This sharp decline in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. This could lead to increased housing costs and reduced attractiveness for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 60 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.5%. This indicates a slowing market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For a worker relocating to this city, the market is becoming more accessible, as they have more time to find and secure a home. However, this trend also suggests a potential normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share composite score of 3.14, ranking at the 68th percentile, Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy roles but may be less ideal for those with primarily industrial or logistics-dominant operations.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the contracting labor force, which poses significant challenges for hiring and talent acquisition, potentially outweighing the city's other advantages.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #33 OF 50

Providence

Providence-Warwick

C+

POOR

43.6th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	48
Unemployment	20% weight	16
Wage Growth	15% weight	46
Cost of Living	12% weight	0
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	92
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	98
Days on Market	5% weight	10
Office Economy	3% weight	68

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	4.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+137.4%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	30 days	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.30% and its extremely high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 9.95, ranking it at the 0th percentile for affordability. The labor demand composite score of 4.64, near the median at the 48th percentile, also plays a significant role in understanding the local economy.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +0.60% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.502% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate expansion in job numbers but with hours worked slightly below trend, indicating some level of genuine demand but not as strong as it could be. The labor demand composite score reflects this balance, sitting near the median.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, which ranks at the 16th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tightness means there is less slack in the market, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in this market, it may require offering competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Providence-Warwick is +3.51% year-over-year, placing it near the median at the 46th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate, and worker purchasing power is increasing, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand. However, it's not high enough to significantly outpace national averages or indicate a highly competitive labor market.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living score that ranks at the 0th percentile, making it one of the most expensive cities relative to its peers, with a PSF of $365/sqft and average hourly earnings of $36.67. This high cost of living, combined with a PSF increase of +9.0% year-over-year, means the city is very expensive and may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent without the natural advantage of affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of +1.69% year-over-year, ranking it at the 92nd percentile. This significant growth indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a larger and potentially more diverse talent pool.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Providence-Warwick has increased by +137.37% year-over-year, placing it at the 98th percentile. This sharp increase signals that housing supply is expected to expand, which could improve affordability and make the city more attractive to potential residents and workers, thereby supporting future workforce growth.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Providence-Warwick is 30 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking it at the 10th percentile. This fast-paced market means homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing, potentially affecting a business's ability to attract out-of-town talent.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy score ranking it at the 68th percentile, indicating a deeper professional talent pool than many of its peers. This makes the city more suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations that rely on specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less ideal for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant.

In conclusion, Providence-Warwick offers a growing labor force and an expanding housing supply, which are positives for businesses considering relocation. However, the city's high cost of living and tight labor market, with its associated wage pressure, are significant factors that decision-makers must carefully weigh, as they could impact operational costs and talent attraction strategies.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #34 OF 50

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

C+

POOR

41.3th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	58
Unemployment	20% weight	10
Wage Growth	15% weight	56
Cost of Living	12% weight	43
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	4
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	82
Days on Market	5% weight	32
Office Economy	3% weight	34

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	4.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.3%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-2.6%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+30.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	33 days	median, +3.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 41.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.90% and its negative labor force growth rate of -2.60% year-over-year. These metrics signal a tight labor market with a shrinking workforce, posing challenges for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +0.08% year-over-year, combined with a +0.475% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend. This signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit a slow one, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.89 ranks near the median at the 58th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 4.90%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This indicates a very tight labor market with little slack, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. Companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract talent in this environment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +4.27%, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while workers are seeing some improvement in their purchasing power. This balance could support a stable business environment.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $220/sqft to $37.11/hr, and a year-over-year increase of 1.4% in PSF, Chicago-Naperville-Elgin ranks near the median at the 43rd percentile in terms of affordability. This means the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers, offering a neutral environment for talent attraction without necessitating significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is contracting at a rate of -2.60% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing, which could limit business expansion plans.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +30.83%, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This significant increase signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future, making the city more attractive for relocating workers.

Days on Market

Homes in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin are currently sitting on the market for 33 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.1%. This below-average market speed, ranking at the 32nd percentile, suggests a relatively accessible housing market for workers relocating to the city, as homes are not selling extremely quickly.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin ranks below average at the 34th percentile. This indicates a less deep talent pool in these areas compared to other metros, making the city less suited for businesses requiring a high concentration of tech, finance, or consulting professionals, but potentially more suitable for industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, Chicago-Naperville-Elgin offers a mixed bag for businesses, with a tight labor market and moderate wage growth, but also a shrinking labor force and a neutral cost of living environment. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the contracting labor force, which could limit hiring capacity and business expansion, necessitating careful planning and strategic recruitment strategies to navigate this challenging labor market.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #35 OF 50

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

C+

POOR

41.2th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	16
Unemployment	20% weight	92
Wage Growth	15% weight	8
Cost of Living	12% weight	8
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	46
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	74
Days on Market	5% weight	82
Office Economy	3% weight	18

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	2.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+19.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	42 days	median, +7.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 41.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 2.60% ranking it in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. Specifically, the employment growth rate of -0.72% and weekly hours deviation of +0.621% signal a contraction in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -0.72%, indicating a decline in job additions, while the weekly hours deviation is +0.621%, suggesting that remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, characteristic of a survivor squeeze. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion in the labor market. The labor demand composite score of 2.67 ranks in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 2.60%, ranking it in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in this city, the low unemployment rate means that attracting and retaining talent will be highly competitive.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is +0.46%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth implies a flat cost environment for employers but weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly, which may impact local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a cost of living score ranking it in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, with a PSF of $168/sqft and an earnings ratio of $32.75/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.13. The city's cost of living is relatively expensive, with PSF increasing by 5.0% year-over-year. This expense means that the city may not have a talent attraction advantage without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is contracting at a rate of -0.76% year-over-year, ranking it near the median at the 46th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to adapt their hiring strategies to accommodate this declining labor force.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has increased by 19.26% year-over-year, ranking it above average at the 74th percentile. This expansion in housing supply signals an improvement in future affordability and workforce accommodation, as more housing units will be available to meet demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.7%, ranking it in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it a more accessible market for workers relocating to the city. However, this trend may also indicate a normalization of the market rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood ranks in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area offers a business a tight labor market with low unemployment, which can be both a challenge and an opportunity. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, which may limit the availability of skilled workers and impact the overall competitiveness of the local economy.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #36 OF 50

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

C+

POOR

39.7th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	18
Unemployment	20% weight	46
Wage Growth	15% weight	22
Cost of Living	12% weight	88
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	68
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	20
Days on Market	5% weight	34
Office Economy	3% weight	54

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.0%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-19.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	57 days	median, -1.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high affordability, with a cost of living score in the top tier. Specifically, the labor demand composite score of 2.86 and the cost of living ratio of $173/sqft to $31.85/hr, which is a 5.43 ratio, set the tone for the local economy.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate is +0.04% year-over-year, and weekly hours are -1.862% below the city's own trend, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are below trend despite minimal job growth. The labor market is not experiencing significant expansion or absorption of new workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate is 3.80%, which places it near the median in terms of tightness, ranking 46th percentile. This rate suggests that the market has some slack, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire compared to extremely tight markets. However, it's not so high as to indicate a severely weak local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is +1.63%, which is below average, ranking 22nd percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising but not at an alarming rate. Worker purchasing power is increasing, but not as quickly as in other metros with faster wage growth.

Cost of Living

San Antonio-New Braunfels is relatively affordable, with a cost of living score in the 88th percentile, indicating it is more affordable than most of its peers. The PSF of $173/sqft is decreasing by -5.0% year-over-year relative to wages of $31.85/hr, making it an attractive location for talent without needing significant wage premiums. This affordability is a talent attraction advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +0.11% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking 68th percentile. This positive growth indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a favorable condition for hiring capacity. Businesses looking to expand or relocate can expect a slightly growing pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -19.15%, indicating a tightening in housing supply. This sharp decline signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation might be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with potential demand. This could lead to increased competition for housing and potentially higher costs.

Days on Market

Homes are currently sitting on the market for a median of 57 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.7%. This relatively fast market, ranking 34th percentile, means that homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The market is somewhat competitive, but not extremely so.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 2.74, ranking near the median at 54th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy, but it may not offer the same level of specialized talent as metros with a higher concentration of professional and office roles. It's less ideal for tech, finance, or consulting businesses that require a very deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro offers businesses an affordable location with a growing labor force, but the biggest risk or constraint is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in attracting and accommodating a growing workforce. Decision-makers should factor in the potential for increased housing costs and competition when considering this location. Overall, the city's economic character is defined by its unique blend of affordability and labor market challenges.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #37 OF 50

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

C+

POOR

39.2th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	26
Unemployment	20% weight	12
Wage Growth	15% weight	64
Cost of Living	12% weight	78
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	60
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	8
Days on Market	5% weight	78
Office Economy	3% weight	22

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	4.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.9%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-24.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	33 days	median, +10.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.26, and its high cost of living affordability, ranking in the 78th percentile. The labor demand and cost of living metrics are the most critical in understanding the city's current economic situation, with employment growth at -0.74% and a cost of living ratio of $221/sqft to $36.90/hr.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -0.74%, and weekly hours are deviating -0.249% from the city's own 12-month baseline, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with the city experiencing a decline in both job creation and working hours. The labor demand composite score of 3.26 is below average, ranking in the 26th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 4.30%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile. This indicates a relatively loose labor market with some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the practical implication is that the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is +4.92%, ranking above average in the 64th percentile. This signals moderate to fast wage growth, which implies rising labor costs for employers but increased purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may face higher labor costs, but workers will have more disposable income to spend in the local economy.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living ratio of $221/sqft to $36.90/hr, with the price per square foot decreasing by -1.3% year-over-year. With a percentile rank of 78, the city is relatively more affordable compared to its peers. This means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums, providing a competitive advantage in terms of talent acquisition.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is growing at a rate of +0.01% year-over-year, ranking in the 60th percentile. Although the growth rate is positive, it is extremely slow, indicating that the labor force supply is barely expanding. This implies that hiring capacity may be limited, and businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has decreased by -24.64% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This signals a tightening of the housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. As a result, the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce may be constrained.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 33 days, with a year-over-year increase of +10.0%. With a percentile rank of 78, the market is relatively slower, indicating that homes are sitting on the market for longer periods. This means that workers relocating to the city may find it more accessible to purchase or rent a home, as the market is less competitive.

Office Economy

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a professional and office worker share of 1.60, ranking below average in the 22nd percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses requiring specialized office or professional workers. The city is best suited for industries that do not rely heavily on a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as logistics or manufacturing, but may be less suitable for tech, finance, or consulting businesses.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and moderate to fast wage growth, but the labor demand is below average, and the housing supply is tightening. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the limited labor force growth and the potential for decreased affordability and increased competition for housing, which may impact the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #38 OF 50

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

C

VERY POOR

37.2th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	10
Unemployment	20% weight	30
Wage Growth	15% weight	80
Cost of Living	12% weight	90
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	2
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	10
Days on Market	5% weight	94
Office Economy	3% weight	2

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-1.0%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-3.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-24.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	49 days	median, +13.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of C, ranking 37.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low labor demand and high cost of living affordability. The city's economic character is most defined by its -0.96% employment growth rate and 6.23% wage growth rate, indicating a complex labor market. Specifically, the combination of low employment growth and high wage growth suggests a tight labor market with upward pressure on wages.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is -0.96% year-over-year, and weekly hours are 0.677% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 2.28 falls in the bottom tier, at the 10th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 3.60%, which is below average, ranking at the 30th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Oklahoma City is 6.23% year-over-year, which is relatively fast. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increased worker purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, while also benefiting from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Oklahoma City has a cost of living score in the top tier, at the 90th percentile, with a PSF of $173/sqft and average hourly earnings of $33.90/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.10. The city's PSF is also falling by 0.6% year-over-year, making it more affordable. This high affordability score means that Oklahoma City has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is shrinking at a rate of -3.01% year-over-year. This contraction in labor supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and recruit new talent. As a result, businesses may need to invest in retention and development programs to maintain their workforce.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Oklahoma City are falling by 24.28% year-over-year. This sharp decline signals a tightening housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and reduced workforce accommodation in the future. As a result, businesses may face challenges in attracting and retaining talent due to limited housing options.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Oklahoma City is 49 days, with a year-over-year increase of 13.9%. This slower market, ranking at the 94th percentile, means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it a more accessible market for relocating workers. However, this may also indicate a normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City's professional and office worker share is 0.38, ranking at the 2nd percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting. Instead, the city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

Oklahoma City offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and low cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent retention and recruitment. However, the city's low labor demand and shrinking labor force pose significant risks to businesses, particularly those requiring specialized talent or relying on a growing workforce. As a result, decision-makers should carefully weigh these factors when considering Oklahoma City as a business location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #39 OF 50

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

C

VERY POOR

36.6th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	36
Unemployment	20% weight	20
Wage Growth	15% weight	48
Cost of Living	12% weight	24
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	98
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	18
Days on Market	5% weight	2
Office Economy	3% weight	60

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+2.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-20.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	25 days	median, -3.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.73. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with employment growth of -0.41% year-over-year, and its top-tier labor force growth of 2.87% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment, with both challenges and opportunities for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is -0.41% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.399% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. As a result, businesses may face a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.90%, which is below average, ranking in the 20th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is +3.66%, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers in the area are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a cost of living score that ranks in the 24th percentile, with a PSF of $497/sqft and average hourly earnings of $46.24/hr, resulting in a ratio of 10.75. The fact that PSF is falling by -1.6% year-over-year is a key driver of the city's relatively low affordability score. This means that the city is less affordable than many of its peers, which can make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is growing at a rate of 2.87% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding rapidly, providing businesses with a growing pool of potential employees. As a result, companies may find it easier to hire and staff their operations in this city.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is declining by -20.56% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which can lead to increased competition for available housing and upward pressure on prices. As a result, future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, making it more challenging for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 25 days, with a year-over-year decline of -3.9%. This indicates a highly competitive market, where homes are selling quickly. As a result, workers relocating to this city may face challenges in finding available housing, making it essential for businesses to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract top talent.

Office Economy

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 60th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suitable for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for companies in the knowledge economy. However, the city's tight labor market, high cost of living, and tightening housing supply pose significant risks and constraints that decision-makers must carefully consider when evaluating this location for their business operations.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #40 OF 50

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

C

VERY POOR

36.3th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	22
Unemployment	20% weight	50
Wage Growth	15% weight	20
Cost of Living	12% weight	18
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	48
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	70
Days on Market	5% weight	66
Office Economy	3% weight	16

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.6%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+13.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	32 days	median, +10.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its below-average labor demand and high cost of living. The labor demand composite score of 3.03, combining a -0.91% employment growth rate and a -0.049% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in job market demand. The cost of living, with a PSF of $227/sqft and an earnings ratio of 6.29, ranks in the 18th percentile, indicating an expensive market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -0.91% and weekly hours deviation of -0.049% from trend indicate a contraction in labor demand, signaling that the job market is not expanding. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing a decline in genuine demand for labor, rather than a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. The below-average labor demand composite score of 3.03 reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.70% places the city near the median, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with neither significant slack nor tightness. For a business trying to hire in this market, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding talent may not be overly challenging, but may also not be exceptionally easy. The near-median ranking implies a stable, though not highly competitive, hiring environment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +1.49% is below average, indicating stagnant to moderate wage growth. This slow wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weaker bargaining power for workers and potentially slower growth in worker purchasing power. The below-average wage growth rate may help keep labor costs in check but could also limit the attractiveness of the area for workers seeking higher pay.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 6.29 and a PSF of $227/sqft that is increasing by 2.2% YoY, the city ranks in the 18th percentile for affordability, indicating an expensive market. This low affordability ranking means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living. The increasing PSF relative to wages further exacerbates the affordability challenge.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of -0.58% year-over-year, indicating a slight contraction in the labor force supply. This negative growth rate suggests that the workforce supply is not expanding, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring in the future. The implication is that businesses may face challenges in finding sufficient talent to meet their needs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +13.09%, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This increase in building permits signals developer confidence and suggests that future housing supply will be more ample, potentially improving affordability and making it easier for workers to relocate to the area. The rising permits are a positive sign for future workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 32 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.3%, placing the city in the 66th percentile for days on market. This indicates a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold, which could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. The rising DOM suggests a normalization of the housing market, potentially reducing pressure on housing prices.

Office Economy

The office economy composite score indicates that the city has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the 16th percentile. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with fewer specialized roles, like logistics or manufacturing.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers a business a relatively stable labor market and expanding housing supply, but its high cost of living and slow labor force growth pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the expensive cost of living, which may necessitate wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially increasing labor costs and affecting the bottom line.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #41 OF 50

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

C

VERY POOR

35.9th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	0
Unemployment	20% weight	34
Wage Growth	15% weight	62
Cost of Living	12% weight	69
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	8
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	88
Days on Market	5% weight	18
Office Economy	3% weight	34

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-2.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-2.5%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+58.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	30 days	median, +3.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score heavily influenced by its poor labor demand and labor force growth metrics, which are both in the bottom tier. The labor demand composite score of 1.50, resulting from -2.86% employment growth YoY and -0.505% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in labor demand. This combination of negative employment growth and below-trend hours worked indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -2.86% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.505% from the city's own 12-month baseline, signaling a contraction in labor demand rather than expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a reduction in job openings and hours worked, which is a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or hire. The labor demand composite score of 1.50 is in the bottom tier, reflecting this weak labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 3.90%, which is below average, ranking in the 34th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire new employees. However, the unemployment rate is not low enough to suggest significant wage pressure or intense competition for workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is +4.85%, which is above average, ranking in the 62nd percentile. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, and worker purchasing power is increasing. As a result, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive in this market.

Cost of Living

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a cost of living score that ranks in the 69th percentile, with a PSF of $310/sqft and average hourly earnings of $44.71/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.93. The fact that PSF is falling by -3.1% YoY relative to wages makes the city more affordable. This affordability advantage can be a talent attraction benefit for businesses, as they may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is growing at a rate of -2.52% YoY, indicating a contraction in the labor force supply. This negative growth rate suggests that the pool of potential workers is shrinking, which could create structural headwinds for businesses looking to hire and expand in the area.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has increased by +58.73% YoY, which is in the top tier, ranking in the 88th percentile. This significant increase in building permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 30 days, with a YoY increase of +3.5%. This indicates a relatively slow market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to this city, the slower market could make it easier to find and purchase a home, but it also suggests a less competitive and less dynamic housing market.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria ranks in the 34th percentile, indicating a below-average depth of professional talent pool. This city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with fewer specialized roles.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average wage growth and an affordable cost of living, which can be beneficial for talent attraction. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's poor labor demand and labor force growth, which could limit hiring capacity and business expansion.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #42 OF 50

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

C

VERY POOR

35.6th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	20
Unemployment	20% weight	22
Wage Growth	15% weight	30
Cost of Living	12% weight	51
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	56
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	40
Days on Market	5% weight	90
Office Economy	3% weight	48

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.4%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+2.3%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-0.9%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-0.1%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-7.4%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
38 days
median, +8.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score reflecting a mix of weak labor demand and moderate cost of living. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand composite score of 3.00, which is in the 20th percentile, and its unemployment rate of 4.40%, indicating a below-average labor market. Specifically, the combination of -0.93% employment growth and -0.632% weekly hours deviation from trend signals a contraction in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -0.93% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.632% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. This suggests that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. The labor demand composite score of 3.00, in the 20th percentile, further reinforces this notion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 4.40%, which is in the 22nd percentile, indicating a below-average labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire workers in this city, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate. The practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that they may have a larger pool of potential candidates to choose from.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +2.32%, which is in the 30th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not as quickly as in cities with faster wage growth. The implication for businesses is that they should expect some upward pressure on labor costs, but not excessively so.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living score in the 51st percentile, with a PSF of $183/sqft and average hourly earnings of $37.15/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.93. This indicates that the city is near the median in terms of affordability, neither particularly expensive nor cheap compared to its peers. This means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent to the area, as the cost of living is relatively balanced.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is growing at a rate of -0.07% year-over-year, which is in the 56th percentile, indicating a near-stable labor force supply. This means that the workforce supply is neither expanding nor contracting significantly, which may limit the city's ability to accommodate rapid hiring growth. The implication for businesses is that they should not expect a rapidly growing labor pool to draw from.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is decreasing by -7.41% year-over-year, which is in the 40th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. The implication for businesses is that they should expect upward pressure on housing costs and potentially more competition for talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is currently 38 days, with a year-over-year increase of +8.6%, which puts it in the 90th percentile, indicating a slower market. This means that workers relocating to the city may find it relatively easier to find a home, as the market is not as competitive as in other cities. The implication for businesses is that they may find it easier to attract talent to the area due to the more accessible housing market.

Office Economy

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has an office economy score in the 48th percentile, indicating a near-median depth of professional talent pool. This means that the city is suited for businesses that require a moderate level of specialized office workers, but may not be the best fit for businesses that require a deep pool of tech, finance, or consulting talent. The city is likely best suited for businesses with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a relatively stable labor force supply and a moderate cost of living, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the weak labor demand, which may limit the city's ability to accommodate rapid hiring growth. The city's tightening housing supply and moderate wage growth also pose potential challenges for businesses looking to attract and retain talent. Overall, businesses should carefully consider these factors when deciding whether to locate in the Detroit-Warren-Dearborn area.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #43 OF 50

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

C

VERY POOR

35.3th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	0
Unemployment	20% weight	12
Wage Growth	15% weight	78
Cost of Living	12% weight	65
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	18
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	76
Days on Market	5% weight	74
Office Economy	3% weight	8

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	4.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-2.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.6%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+23.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	47 days	median, +6.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking in the 35.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 1.50 and an unemployment rate of 4.80%. The city's economic character is most defined by its negative employment growth rate of -2.85% and above-average wage growth of +6.21%. These metrics suggest a complex labor market with both challenges and opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is -2.85%, and weekly hours are deviating -0.220% from the city's own 12-month baseline, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with the city experiencing a decline in job creation. The negative hours deviation suggests that the remaining workforce is not absorbing additional hours, which could be a sign of a weakening labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 4.80%, which is relatively high, indicating some slack in the labor market. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate. However, the 12th percentile rank suggests that the market is still relatively competitive, and businesses may need to offer attractive compensation packages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is +6.21%, which is above average, ranking in the 78th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have stronger purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to adjust their pricing strategies to account for the increasing labor costs, while also benefiting from the increased consumer demand driven by higher wages.

Cost of Living

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a cost of living score that ranks in the 65th percentile, with a PSF of $310/sqft and average hourly earnings of $42.24/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.34. The city's cost of living is relatively affordable, with the PSF decreasing by -2.5% year-over-year. This makes it an attractive location for talent, as workers can afford a relatively high standard of living without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is growing at a rate of -1.57% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This negative growth rate suggests that the city's workforce supply is shrinking, which could create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion. As a result, businesses may need to invest in workforce development programs or consider relocating to areas with more abundant labor supplies.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has increased by +23.17% year-over-year, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This growth in building permits suggests that developer confidence is rising, and the city's future housing supply is likely to increase, which could improve affordability and attract more workers to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is currently 47 days, with a year-over-year increase of +6.8%. This relatively slow market means that workers relocating to the city may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, which could be an advantage for businesses looking to attract talent. However, the rising days on market could also indicate a normalization of the housing market, rather than a sign of weakening demand.

Office Economy

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a professional and office worker share of 0.68, ranking in the 8th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. The city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies. However, it may not be the most attractive location for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on specialized office workers.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers a complex mix of challenges and opportunities for businesses, with above-average wage growth and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the city's negative employment growth rate and contracting labor force pose significant risks for businesses looking to expand or relocate to the area, and decision-makers should carefully consider these factors when evaluating the city's potential as a business location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #44 OF 50

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

C

VERY POOR

34.5th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	42
Unemployment	20% weight	84
Wage Growth	15% weight	38
Cost of Living	12% weight	4
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	0
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	4
Days on Market	5% weight	6
Office Economy	3% weight	10

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-7.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-30.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	30 days	median, -3.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 4.16. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.60% and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 6.88, indicating a relatively expensive market. The labor force growth rate of -6.97% YoY also significantly impacts the city's economic outlook.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is -0.10% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.605% from the city's own 12-month baseline, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, as both job growth and hours worked are below trend. The labor demand composite score of 4.16, near the median, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 3.60%, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile, indicating a tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the low unemployment rate puts upward pressure on wages. The tight market implies that employers may need to offer competitive salaries to attract talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is +2.97%, which is below average, ranking at the 38th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. As a result, worker purchasing power is increasing, but not as rapidly as in cities with faster wage growth.

Cost of Living

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a cost of living percentile rank of 4th, indicating that it is relatively expensive, with a PSF to wages ratio of 6.88. The city's PSF is $224/sqft, which has increased by 8.7% YoY, making it less affordable for residents. This high cost of living may deter talent from relocating to the area without wage premiums, putting businesses at a disadvantage in attracting workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is contracting at a rate of -6.97% YoY, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This decline in labor force growth poses a significant structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may struggle to find qualified workers to fill open positions. The implication is that companies may need to invest in training and development programs to upskill existing employees.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has decreased by -30.86% YoY, signaling a tightening of housing supply. This sharp decline in building permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the limited housing supply may drive up prices and rents. As a result, businesses may face challenges in attracting and retaining workers due to the lack of affordable housing options.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 30 days, with a YoY decrease of -3.2%. Although the days on market are relatively low, the decrease indicates a competitive market. However, the low days on market percentile rank of 6th suggests that homes are still selling relatively quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing options.

Office Economy

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a professional and office worker share of 0.84, ranking at the 10th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies. In contrast, tech, finance, and consulting firms may find it challenging to attract and retain specialized talent in this market.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers businesses a tight labor market with low unemployment, but this comes with the challenge of high labor costs and a competitive hiring environment. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the shrinking labor force, which may limit hiring capacity and require investments in employee training and development. Overall, companies should carefully weigh the benefits and drawbacks of locating in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood, considering the potential impact on their workforce and operations.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #45 OF 50

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

C

VERY POOR

34.3th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	54
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	14
Cost of Living	12% weight	14
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	16
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	32
Days on Market	5% weight	86
Office Economy	3% weight	24

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.5%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+1.1%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.4%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-1.7%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-13.7%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
41 days
median, +7.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low wage growth and high cost of living. The city's economic character is defined by its stagnant wage growth of +1.14% YoY and a cost of living ratio of 9.01, with $344/sqft versus $38.20/hr. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +0.44% YoY, while weekly hours are -0.101% below trend, indicating a near-median labor demand composite score of 4.81. This combination signals a modest expansion of jobs, but with hours worked below trend, it may not represent genuine demand expansion. The labor market is not experiencing significant contraction, but the below-trend hours worked suggest some level of inefficiency.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 4.50%, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This indicates a moderate level of slack in the labor market, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively high unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +1.14%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This stagnant wage growth signals a flat cost environment for employers, but it also means weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. Businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but the slow wage growth could impact worker morale and retention.

Cost of Living

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a cost of living ratio of 9.01, with $344/sqft versus $38.20/hr, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This means the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The high cost of living could be a significant constraint for businesses looking to relocate or expand in the area.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is contracting at a rate of -1.68% YoY, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking.

Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified candidates, which could impact their growth and expansion plans.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is -13.71%, ranking below average at the 32nd percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability challenges and make it harder for workers to relocate to the area. The decreasing supply of housing could exacerbate the existing cost of living issues.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 41 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.9%, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to the city, this could be a positive sign, as it may indicate a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 1.62, ranking below average at the 24th percentile. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors. The city may be better suited for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers a moderate labor market with some challenges in terms of cost of living and labor force growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the high cost of living, which could make it difficult to attract and retain talent without offering significant wage premiums. Decision-makers should carefully consider this factor when evaluating the city as a potential location for their business.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #46 OF 50

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

C-

CRITICAL

30.9th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	6
Unemployment	20% weight	66
Wage Growth	15% weight	32
Cost of Living	12% weight	37
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	26
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	24
Days on Market	5% weight	38
Office Economy	3% weight	4

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	4.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.3%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.8%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-18.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	38 days	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and stagnant labor force growth, with a labor demand composite score of 1.91 ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, and labor force growth of -1.41% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is -0.80% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating 1.27% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 1.91 is in the bottom tier, ranking 6th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is 4.00%, ranking in the 66th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure. The market has some slack, but it is still relatively competitive.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is +2.34%, ranking in the 32nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but at a moderate pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing. However, the wage growth is not strong enough to drive significant economic expansion.

Cost of Living

Louisville-Jefferson County has a cost of living score ranking in the 37th percentile, with a PSF of $180/sqft and average hourly earnings of $31.28, resulting in a ratio of 5.75. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The lack of affordability may make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Louisville-Jefferson County is contracting at a rate of -1.41% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find the talent they need. The declining labor force growth rate is a concern for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Louisville-Jefferson County is -18.58%, indicating a tightening housing supply. This signals a potential supply squeeze, which may lead to decreased affordability and make it challenging for the workforce to find accommodation. The decline in building permits is a concern for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Louisville-Jefferson County is 38 days, with no year-over-year change. This indicates a relatively stable market, but still relatively competitive for workers relocating to the city. The days on market are not rising, which is a positive sign, but the market is not particularly accessible either.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Louisville-Jefferson County is 0.44, ranking in the 4th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This makes the city less suited for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors, but more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses. The lack of a deep professional talent pool is a concern for businesses looking to establish a headquarters or office operations.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with moderate wage growth, but it also presents significant challenges, including a shrinking labor force, tightening housing supply, and a relatively expensive cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the declining labor force growth rate, which may limit the city's ability to attract and retain talent, making it challenging for businesses to expand or relocate.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #47 OF 50

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

C-

CRITICAL

30.8th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	24
Unemployment	20% weight	22
Wage Growth	15% weight	68
Cost of Living	12% weight	33
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	14
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	26
Days on Market	5% weight	46
Office Economy	3% weight	0

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.4%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.0%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-2.2%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-18.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **56 days** median, +5.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.03, and its above-average wage growth of 5.40% year-over-year. The labor demand and wage growth metrics signal a complex economic environment, with slow job growth and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate is 0.01% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -1.281% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a lack of genuine demand expansion. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, with hours below trend during a period of slow job growth. The labor demand composite score of 3.03 ranks below average, at the 24th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate is 4.90%, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile, indicating a moderate level of slack in the labor market. This means that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still some competition for talent. The practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that it may face some wage pressure, but not as much as in tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is 5.40%, which is above average, ranking at the 68th percentile. This signals fast wage growth, which implies rising labor costs for employers and increased purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but workers will have more disposable income to spend in the local economy.

Cost of Living

The city has a cost of living score with a PSF of $337/sqft, which is decreasing by 2.3% year-over-year, and an earnings ratio of $35.23/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.57, ranking below average at the 33rd percentile. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The decreasing PSF is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score remains low.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -2.20% year-over-year, ranking at the 14th percentile, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development programs to build the skills they need.

Building Permits

The number of building permits is decreasing by 18.08% year-over-year, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This signals a potential future affordability crisis and workforce accommodation challenges, as the supply of housing is not keeping pace with demand. The decrease in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a stable and affordable housing market to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market is 56 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.7%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This means that the housing market is relatively balanced, neither extremely competitive nor extremely accessible. Workers relocating to this city may face a moderate level of competition for housing, but the market is not overly challenging.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 0.16, ranking at the 0th percentile, indicating a very shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is best suited for businesses that do not rely heavily on professional or office workers, such as industrial or logistics companies. On the other hand, it may not be the best fit for tech, finance, or consulting firms that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers a complex economic environment with both opportunities and challenges for businesses. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor pool and tightening housing supply, which could limit the city's ability to attract and retain talent. Despite these challenges, the city's above-average wage growth and moderate unemployment rate may still make it an attractive location for certain types of businesses.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #48 OF 50

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

C-

CRITICAL

30.6th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	32
Unemployment	20% weight	40
Wage Growth	15% weight	10
Cost of Living	12% weight	22
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	42
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	36
Days on Market	5% weight	44
Office Economy	3% weight	12

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-12.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	34 days	median, +3.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.68, and stagnant wage growth of +0.51% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is -0.44% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.099% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, with the labor market experiencing a slowdown. The labor demand composite score of 3.68 ranks below average at the 32nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 3.80%, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire, but still with some wage pressure. However, the relatively low unemployment rate may still pose challenges for businesses looking to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +0.51%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This stagnant wage growth signals a flat cost environment for employers, but weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but workers may not have strong purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a cost of living score ranking below average at the 22nd percentile, with a PSF of $214/sqft and average hourly earnings of $39.19/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.46. The PSF is falling -0.5% year-over-year, making the city relatively less affordable compared to peers. This may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the city's affordability is not a significant advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is contracting at a rate of -0.90% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile. This signals a shrinking labor pool, posing a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers to fill open positions.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is falling -11.97% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This decline in building permits signals a tightening housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation. This could pose a risk to businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 34 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.0%. This suggests a relatively slow market, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market may be more accessible, but still competitive, with homes taking around a month to sell.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 0.90, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors. However, the city may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers businesses a relatively slow labor market with stagnant wage growth, which may help keep labor costs in check. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor pool and tightening housing supply, which may pose significant challenges for attracting and retaining talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #49 OF 50

Richmond

Richmond

C-

CRITICAL

29.6th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	8
Unemployment	20% weight	58
Wage Growth	15% weight	40
Cost of Living	12% weight	26
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	40
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	6
Days on Market	5% weight	26
Office Economy	3% weight	30

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	3.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-28.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	36 days	median, -2.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 29.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand composite score of 2.22, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, and its building permits decline of -28.08% year-over-year, also in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. These metrics signal significant challenges in the local job market and future housing supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.54% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +1.323% above its own trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 2.22 reinforces this interpretation, indicating a weak job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.40%, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This suggests a relatively balanced market with neither significant tightness nor slack. For a business trying to hire in Richmond, this means that while it may not be extremely difficult to find workers, there is also not a large surplus of unemployed individuals to draw from.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Richmond is +3.03%, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely quickly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not dramatically. This could be seen as a relatively stable labor cost environment.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score ranking it at the 26th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $232/sqft to $36.20/hr, or 6.41. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is rising +2.2% year-over-year relative to wages further exacerbates this issue. This could make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is shrinking at a rate of -0.93% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified candidates due to this shrinking labor pool.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Richmond has declined by -28.08% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This sharp decline signals a tightening of future housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more difficult for the workforce to find accommodation. This is a significant risk for businesses relying on a mobile workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Richmond is 36 days, with a year-over-year decline of -2.7%. This relatively fast market, ranking below average at the 26th percentile, means that homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. This fast pace may indicate a competitive market for homebuyers.

Office Economy

Richmond's professional and office worker share ranks below average at the 30th percentile, with a composite score of 1.86. This suggests that while there is some depth to the professional talent pool, it is not as pronounced as in other cities. Richmond is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

The Richmond metro area presents a mixed bag for businesses, with challenges in labor demand, housing supply, and cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, signaling a potential future affordability crisis and workforce accommodation challenges. This could significantly impact businesses relying on a mobile and growing workforce, making it essential to carefully consider these factors in any location decision.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #50 OF 50

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

D

EMERGENCY

22.1th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	12
Unemployment	20% weight	4
Wage Growth	15% weight	16
Cost of Living	12% weight	35
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	50
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	34
Days on Market	5% weight	36
Office Economy	3% weight	50

KEY INDICATORS

Indicator	Value	Detail
UNEMPLOYMENT	4.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.5%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-12.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	59 days	median, -1.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Jacksonville has an overall grade of D, ranking 22.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its low labor demand and high unemployment rate, at 4.80%. The labor demand composite score of 2.55, combining a -0.42% employment growth rate and a +1.167% weekly hours deviation, signals a contraction in job market activity. These metrics suggest a challenging economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Jacksonville is -0.42% year-over-year, while weekly hours are running 1.167% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 2.55 falls in the bottom tier, at the 12th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.80%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with significant slack, making it easier for businesses to staff but also suggesting weaker local consumer demand. Businesses trying to hire in this market may face less competition for talent.

Wage Growth

Year-over-year wage growth in Jacksonville is +1.23%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests a relatively flat cost environment for employers, but also implies weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, worker purchasing power is not increasing rapidly.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living score corresponding to a 35th percentile rank, with a PSF of $218/sqft and average hourly earnings of $36.76/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.93. Since PSF is falling by 2.7% year-over-year, the city is relatively more affordable compared to its peers. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is shrinking at a rate of -0.49% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified candidates.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Jacksonville are falling by 12.00% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. This decline in permits suggests a tightening housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. Developer confidence appears to be waning.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Jacksonville is 59 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.7%. This relatively fast market, ranking below average at the 36th percentile, may make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The market is competitive, favoring sellers over buyers.

Office Economy

Jacksonville's professional and office worker share corresponds to a near-median percentile rank of 50th. The city has a moderately deep talent pool, making it suited for businesses that do not require a highly specialized knowledge-economy workforce. While it may not be ideal for tech, finance, or consulting headquarters, it could accommodate other types of businesses.

The city of Jacksonville presents a challenging economic environment for businesses, with low labor demand and a shrinking labor force supply being major concerns. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the potential difficulty in finding and hiring qualified talent, given the tightening labor market and decreasing labor force. Despite some affordability advantages, these challenges may outweigh the benefits of locating in Jacksonville.